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Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion Programming for African American Students at Predominantly White Institutions

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CAPSTONE

Submitted in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements

For the Degree of Doctorate of Education, Ed.D.
Interdisciplinary Leadership, HEAD Concentration

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ABSTRACT

This qualitative study explores the impact of student support programs on the success of African American students in higher education. While existing research emphasizes the need for diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming and highlights longstanding disparities affecting African Americans in education, limited attention has been given to the influence of student support programs and the role of belonging in terms of academic success. Furthermore, the lived experience and narratives of African American students remain underrepresented in the literature.

This study examined the perspective of nine graduates from a student support program at a predominantly White institution (PWI) in the Midwest. Through semi-structured interviews, three key themes emerged: (a) student support programs fostered inclusiveness and a sense of belonging; (b) campus organizations helped build community and inclusion; and (c) participants reported lack of belonging in interactions with community authority figures. These findings suggest that student support programs play a critical role in promoting DEI and cultivating a sense of belonging, both of which contribute significantly to the academic success of African American students at PWIs.

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DEDICATION

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CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

This study investigates the role of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming in supporting African American students at a public Predominantly White Institution (PWI) in Illinois. It focuses on how participation in a student support program fosters academic achievement, personal development, and a sense of belonging among African American students. While student support services are valuable to all students, this research emphasizes their distinct significance for African American students, who often face systemic barriers in higher education environments.

In recent years, higher education institutions have increased efforts to implement inclusive practices and prioritize DEI initiatives (Clayton, 2021). The COVID-19 pandemic further illuminated longstanding disparities and inequities in access, resources, and outcomes. Despite these developments, African American students continue to face challenges due to systemic racism and insufficient institutional support (Allen et al., 2018). Many still report a lack of belonging and culturally responsive support structures in public PWIs (Wright-Mair, 2020). This study aims to address these gaps by examining how student support programming contributes to inclusion and success.

Background

The historical roots of educational inequity are evident in policies such as the Morrill Land Grant Act of 1862, which initially excluded African Americans from access to federally funded institutions. While the Act eventually expanded educational opportunities for Black students, challenges have persisted. Landmark Supreme Court decisions like *Plessy v. Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education* have had complex legacies. Some scholars argue that Plessy

institutionalized segregation, while Brown began dismantling it (Powell et al., 2021). Despite legal progress, African Americans remain underrepresented in higher education. Structural inequities and discriminatory practices continue to affect their academic trajectories (Ware, 2021).

Context of the Problem

Despite landmark initiatives like the Truman Commission and Higher Education Act, which sought to expand educational opportunities for African Americans, underrepresentation in college enrollment, retention, and graduation rates persist. Sotto-Santiago (2020) explained that while higher education has made progress in advancing diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI), there remains a pressing need for a more comprehensive and integrated mission and vision. African Americans often find themselves working twice as hard to prove their worth in a system that continues to present inequitable challenges (Sotto-Santiago, 2020).

It is important to recognize that DEI initiatives have their detractors. Much of the opposition to DEI programs comes from privileged groups (Iyer, 2022). These groups argue that such programs fail to address the root causes of social inequality, squander time and resources, and potentially create conflict between groups (Iyer, 2022). However, the potential benefits—fostering a more inclusive and equitable society—far outweigh these concerns.

Historically, some believe that higher education has been inhospitable to inclusive environments, and university administrators in student affairs often treat everyone the same regardless of race. Tevis and Pifer (2021) noted that this is not always the case, as significant differences exist in how students experience higher education. Strayhorn (2019) emphasizes the fact that in higher education, especially in PWIs, the academic and sense of belonging needs of African Americans are frequently unmet, a disparity that often contributes to lower retention

rates among this among this population. These findings underscore the urgency of cultivating truly inclusive environments that address the needs of all students, which necessarily includes African Americans.

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to explore the impact of student support programming on the success of African American students at a public PWI in Illinois. The research will investigate how DEI-grounded 1 programs address gaps in inclusion and belonging and how they contribute to student success. By examining both institutional practices and student experiences, the study seeks to identify effective strategies and reveal opportunities for improvement.

Theoretical Framework

Throughout this paper, the concepts of sense of belonging and Critical Race Theory (CRT) will be examined. Strayhorn (2019) defines a sense of belonging as a feeling of connectedness in which an individual perceives themselves as essential, valued, and important to others. Delgado and Stefancic (2023) define CRT as a movement of activists and scholars that study and transform relationships of race, racism, and power. In this research, the CRT will be used to assist in explaining the historical component of DEI programming and systemic racism, while the sense of belonging theory will be applied to explore the experiences and disparities faced by African Americans, as well as the importance of fostering a sense of belonging. In a diverse, multicultural society, the desire to feel valued, included, and free from marginalization is universal. African Americans share this sentiment yet often face unique challenges in achieving it.

CRT, first introduced in the 1970s and 1980s, addresses the persistent lack of equality that is often systematically reinforced (Reece, 2021). These inequalities are typically embedded

in laws, policies, and institutional practices (Reece, 2021). Much of what African Americans experience in relation to DEI programming has deep historical roots in systemic inequities affecting underrepresented populations, particularly African Americans. This research will examine these historical inequalities and highlight the need for DEI programming through the narratives, perspectives, and experiences of nine students from a Midwest PWI student support program.

The sense of belonging theory, which gained prominence in the 20th century, underscores the fundamental human need to feel connected and included (Strayhorn, 2019). This theory is central to understanding the experiences of African American students within the context of DEI programming. It elucidates the significance of their sense of belonging, feelings of inclusiveness, and the role of a student support program at a Midwest PWI in cultivating these outcomes.

This research will explore the narratives of stakeholders, specifically the referenced nine African American students who have attended one public PWI in Illinois. Insight into their experiences will be obtained through interviews designed to identify common themes and perspectives related to inclusive programming. By examining the lived experiences of African American students at a Midwest public PWI in Illinois, the findings of this research aim to encourage higher education leaders and policymakers to view inclusive programs not only as an institutional commitment but a moral responsibility. Ultimately, the findings are intended to inspire advocacy for African American students— and all students—to become active agents of change in shaping student support programming and fostering belonging at PWIs in Illinois.

Research Question

This research is guided by the central question: *How does DEI programming impact inclusiveness and support a sense of belonging among African American college students?* This

research will additionally examine how DEI-grounded student support programming fosters the growth, development, and mental health of African American college students. This research question will be explored through qualitative research. The purpose of which is to understand how African American college students make sense of their lived experiences and to understand, interpret, and unfold these experiences (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Addressing and bridging the detrimental gaps in DEI programming is of utmost urgency. To dismantle the system, data must be collected that captures the lived experiences of these students and the history of African Americans in higher education. In this regard, using scholarly literature and conducting interviews are imperative.

In addition, scholarly research on equity plans of PWIs and real-life experiences of African American college students through interviews will be examined. Finally, suggestions for implementing these institutions will be used for recommendations and future implications after research is gathered. In all, detrimental gaps and systematic structures that hinder African Americans will be explored, as well as insights on how we can dismantle the system in higher education to benefit African American students.

This research will explore the stories of African American students who have attended a Midwest public PWI in Illinois, student support program, to gain insight into their perspectives and experiences as they relate to inclusiveness and a sense of belonging. Nine African American former student support program students from a Midwest PWI will be interviewed. The interviews will detail their experiences and barriers and give a real-life account of their events at these institutions related to DEI programming and belonging.

Moreover, implications for this research are that the marginalized and underrepresented population of African American students, who often fall into this arena, are often left behind.

Further findings intend to stimulate growth, development, and advocacy for African American students and all students in general, to become agents of change for student support programming. Other intentions are to dismantle our systems and structures and highlight what African American students need to succeed within PWIs. The following terms have been operationalized for the purpose of the study.

Definition of Terms

Sense of Belonging: A feeling of connectedness that one is essential and matters and is also important to others.

Critical Race Theory: The idea that race is a social construction, and inequalities as a social construction are supported by law, policies, and institutions.

Interest conversion: The idea that racism benefits elite and working-class whites, and therefore, society has little interest in eliminating it.

Social construction: The idea that race is a result of social thought and relations.

Racialization: How society racializes different groups at different times of need in the laboring market.

Storytelling: African Americans and other minority groups retell their experiences with racism, race, and daily life.

CHAPTER II

LITERATURE REVIEW

DEI is not merely a contemporary concern but an urgent priority requiring immediate attention across many universities (Clayton, 2021). Ongoing DEI initiatives for marginalized populations, particularly African Americans, highlight the pressing need for systemic change (Allen et al., 2018). Institutions of higher education have implemented strategic measures to foster progress, especially among African American students. The COVID-19 pandemic provided many universities with the opportunity to confront and address long-standing equity issues (Clayton, 2021).

While DEI initiatives have gained visibility, there has been considerable debate regarding the validity and historical foundation of their components. For example, *Plessy v. Ferguson* upheld the constitutionality of "separate but equal" laws, a decision that, although perhaps framed as progressive at the time, entrenched structural inequality. Ware (2021) asserted that federal policies and rulings not only damaged our school's systematic structure but also perpetuated segregation—beginning in the South and extending to neighborhoods, housing, and carceral systems. Although civil rights legislation has produced notable advancements in DEI programming, Ware argues that significant work remains. Reece (2021) similarly contends that *Plessy v. Ferguson* provided a legal and discriminatory framework that continues to impede African Americans' advancement today.

Leadership plays a pivotal role in transforming inclusive programming from concept to reality. In higher education, leaders must promote and create inclusive organizational structures that serve increasingly diverse student populations (Evatt-Young & Bryson, 2021). Their

responsibilities include dismantling systemic and organizational biases to ensure transparent DEI program implementation (Evatt-Young & Bryson, 2021).

The urgency of critically assessing DEI programming is particularly evident for African Americans, who have historically faced exclusion within PWIs (Iyer, 2022). This study draws upon two theoretical frameworks to address this issue: the Sense of Belonging Theory and Critical Race Theory (CRT), both of which provide insights into African Americans' experiences and the educational disparities that they face.

The Sense of Belonging and Critical Race Theory

The concept of belonging was introduced by Abraham Maslow (1954) within his hierarchy of human needs. Strayhorn (2019) defines a sense of belonging as a feeling of connectedness and significance within a shared community. Strayhorn (2019) further notes that the absence of this sense of belonging is characterized by "alienation, loneliness, and rejection" (Strayhorn, 2019, p. 22). According to Strayhorn (2019), students lacking this sense of belonging often leave college prematurely and perceive their academic experience as transactional rather than fulfilling. They interpret their college experience as "stopping by the mall" (p 22). Wright-Mair (2020) emphasized that underrepresented populations require inclusive and welcoming environments to thrive. Without belonging, students are vulnerable to low self-esteem, depression, and in severe cases, suicidal ideation (Strayhorn, 2019). Strayhorn argues that a sense of belonging benefits all students by fostering a collective "we" mindset (p.22). Wright-Mair (2020) advocates for the establishment of campus equity centers—safe spaces where students with shared identities can connect—thereby promoting diversity and belonging.

Vacarro et al. (2019) noted that belonging is especially challenging for students from marginalized social identity groups, who often experience both 'overt and subtle' exclusion,

referring to both direct and indirect forms of discrimination (p. 33). Research consistently finds that students of color report lower levels of belonging than their White peers (Vacarro et al., 2019). Wright-Mair (2020) further explained that a sense of connection and belonging within a university enables diverse student populations to feel seen, heard, and valued.

Within this study, the sense of belonging theory is applied to African American students' experiences at PWIs, highlighting the challenges of fostering inclusion in such environments. Research will be conducted through in-depth interviews while developing themes and conducting analysis. The framework combines with Critical Race Theory (CRT) to underscore the need for intentional strategies to create deep connections—both social and spatial—that support African Americans' academic success.

Critical Race Theory (CRT) emerged in the 1970s and 1980s as a response to persistent racial inequalities that endured despite the legal end of segregation (Reece, 2021). This theory posits that race is a social construct, and that systemic inequalities are perpetuated by laws, policies, and institutional practices (Reece, 2021). While segregation has ended, legal and policy structures continue to support racial inequities (Reece, 2021).

Jones et al. (2022) observed that CRT grew out of legal studies and the recognition of unfulfilled promises left unaddressed overtime. CRT identifies that there are still inequities and ongoing racism as it relates to legal systems in higher education. Templeton (2016) explained that the CRT distinguishes how racial minorities have been "socially, structurally, and intellectually marginalized" in the United States (p. 6). Delgado and Stefancic (2023) explained that CRT is a movement that questions the foundation of liberal order, equality, and principles of constitutional law.

Delgado and Stefancic (2023) outlined five core tenets of CRT, the first being that racism is ordinary. In this way, racism becomes a common infraction that is difficult to address and often concealed by colorblind ideologies. For example, an African American with a Ph.D. may face greater employment barriers than a White college dropout.

The second tenet is interest conversion. This tenet suggests that Racial progress occurs only when it aligns with the interests of the dominant group. The dominant group in the case of the United States would be elite and working-class whites. Unless progress will directly benefit this group, society has little interest in eliminating racism (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023). Delgado and Stefancic (2023) highlight *Brown v. Board of Education* in this tenet and express that this victory may have benefited the self-interest of elite whites and not from an aspiration to help African Americans.

According to Delgado and Stefancic (2023), the third tenet, social construction, is the idea that race is not biologically determined but is created and maintained through perceptions and social relations. Delgado and Stefancic (2023) expressed that there are many times when society will ignore biological aspects of race and navigate towards racial classification as it relates to a more social pattern, a social construct. In other words, Races are categorized by society's inventions and manipulation (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023).

The fourth tenet of CRT is racialization. Racialization occurs when groups are racialized differently depending on socio-economic and labor market needs (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023). Delgado and Stefancic (2023) use the example of African Americans once being considered less useful in agriculture than other minority groups. Likewise, Muslims shifted from being perceived primarily as devout worshippers to being viewed as security threats in the aftermath of events of September 11th, 2001.

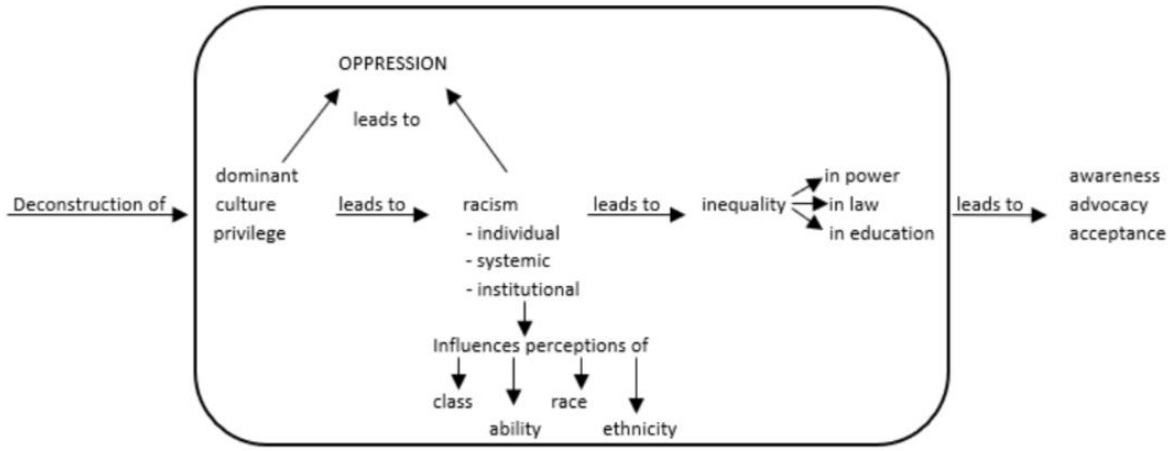
The fifth and final tenet of CRT according to Delgado and Stefancic (2023) is storytelling. African Americans and other minority groups are encouraged to share personal narratives allowing their perspectives and lived experiences to unfold to their white counterparts, who may otherwise remain unaware (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023).

These five tenets of CRT illuminate the pervasive influence of race and racism on African Americans' educational experiences at PWIs, as well as the unconscious biases embedded in societal structures. In this study, CRT provides a framework and a structural lens for understanding systemic inequities that are made manifest in laws, policies, and institutional practices in higher education, while the sense of belonging theory addresses the interpersonal and emotional dimensions necessary for student success. Together, they underscore the importance of creating environments in which African Americans not only have access to higher education but also feel valued and supported within it (Wright-Mair, 2020).

The following figures provide a visual reference for the manifestation of these theories.

Figure 1

The Critical Race Theory

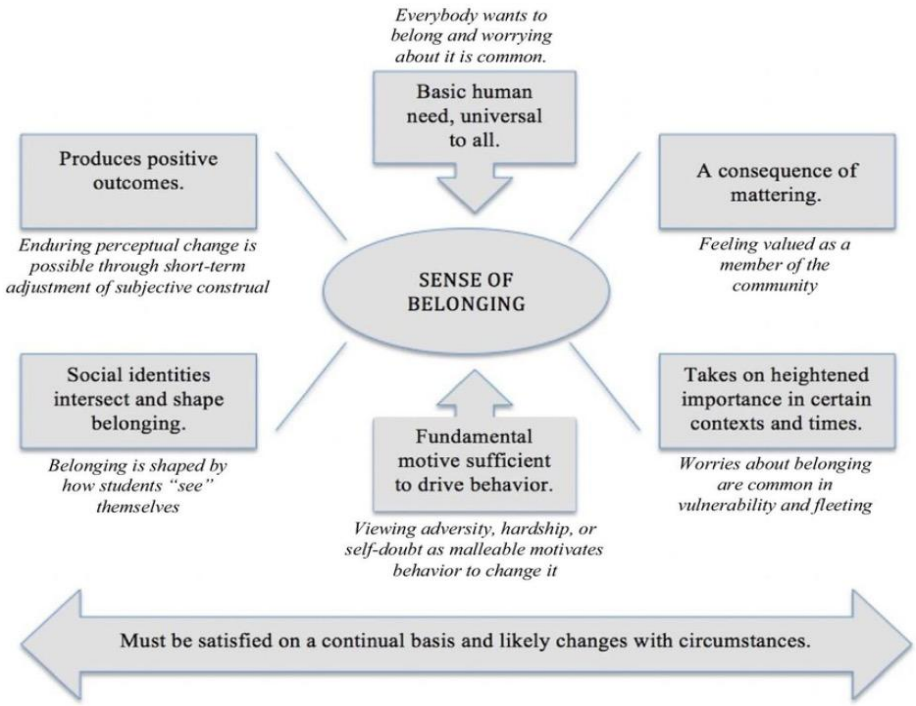


Note: This figure illustrates the CRT and entails concepts and constructs of the theory (Movius, 2020).

As illustrated in Figure 1, Critical Race Theory (CRT) serves as a framework for deconstructing smaller concepts to develop an understanding of oppression and the underlying causes of racism (Movius, 2020). The figure depicts how deconstructing the dominant, privilege-centered culture reveals the mechanisms that perpetuate oppression and racism. According to Movius (2020), racism may manifest at individual, systemic, or institutional levels, each contributing to inequities in power, law, and education. These inequities, in turn, create the conditions for increased awareness, advocacy, and, ultimately, acceptance.

Figure 2

Sense of Belonging Theory



Note: This figure illustrates Strayhorn's (2021) Framework of College Student Sense of Belonging Theory developed.

As shown in Figure 2, Strayhorn's (2021) illustration of the Sense of Belonging Theory identifies several key principles. A sense of belonging is a fundamental human need that

produces positive outcomes and is shaped by the intersection of social identities. It operates as a foundational motive capable of driving behavior, emerges because of mattering, and takes on heightened importance in specific contexts and times. Strayhorn (2021) concludes that a sense of belonging is essential for individual well-being and, in alignment with Wright-Mair's (2020) findings, is necessary for individuals to thrive.

This research contends that Critical Race Theory (CRT) and the Sense of Belonging Theory together provide a necessary foundation for examining diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming at public predominantly White institutions (PWIs). CRT offers a lens for analyzing systemic structures, policies, and colorblind practices that limit opportunities for African Americans. The Sense of Belonging Theory illustrates how student support programs influence the success of African American students at PWIs and foster a sense of belonging within these environments. The following literature review section establishes the scholarly foundation and rationale for this study.

Review of Relevant Literature

The purpose of this research is to examine diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming for African American students and its relationships to student support programs at public, predominantly White institutions (PWIs). This study seeks to understand how universities integrate inclusive programming, particularly for African American students, and to analyze the institutional role in advancing such efforts. It further investigates how programs at PWIs cultivate a sense of belonging among African American students and how this sense of belonging contributes to their academic and personal success. The exploration will address the following areas: the history of DEI, historical cases grounded in DEI, legislation shaping DEI, current DEI related cases, existing disparities and gaps, the relationship between DEI programming and the

mental health of African Americans, equity planning at PWIS, leadership commitment to DEI, and the implementation and practices aimed at improving campus climate.

For centuries, institutions have faced challenges in achieving DEI (Allen et al., 2018). Questions involving how to effectively implement and uphold commitments to equity have persisted, particularly related to African American students (Allen et al., 2018). Efforts to create inclusive environments for marginalized populations, especially African Americans, have been ongoing but remain incomplete. Although progress has been made over time, continued and deliberate action is necessary to address remaining inequities.

History of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

The Morrill Land Grant Act of 1862 opened the door for African Americans to obtain an education through federal land grants at a time when historically White colleges and PWIs would not (Allen et al., 2018). Historically Black colleges and universities (HBCUs), such as Spelman College, Morehouse College, and other colleges, were initially established to provide educational opportunities for African Americans. However, African Americans still experienced educational hardships over the years. Federal land grants funded African American schooling in earlier years (Allen et al., 2018).

Historically Black colleges and universities were established under the Morrill Land Grant Act, allowing African Americans to attend college after being denied access to HWIs and PWIs (Allen et al., 2018). However, with the separate but equal law overturned in the federal court, African Americans were later allowed to attend these colleges. In addition, Allen et al. (2018) explained that despite this advancement, African Americans still experience the disadvantages of systematic racism and lack of implementation of equity-based policies (Allen et al., 2018, p. 44). African Americans experience inequalities in enrollment, retention rates, and

inequitable access to resources, as well as underrepresentation among diverse faculty (Allen et al., 2018).

The Truman Commission Act also influenced the development of inclusive programming. The Truman Commission Act was established to promote equity in higher education for the first time in 1947 (Gilbert & Heller, 2013). When this Act was implemented, the need for diversity, even then, was certainly well understood. The Truman Commission Act called for significant changes in education, established a network of community colleges, and sought to improve college access and equity in education. Gilbert and Heller (2013) also explained that during this time, there was a call to remove racial discrimination, which was prevalent during this period.

In addition, the Truman Commission Act recommended ending discrimination based on race and religious discrimination, doing away with anti-feminism, and eliminating financial barriers. The Commission acknowledged that race played a considerable hindrance during the Commission Act and that dismantling racism was at a critical point. The commission focused on improving and safeguarding civil rights during this time. Gilbert and Heller (2013) expressed that despite the commission's efforts and other cases to follow, such as *Brown v. Board of Education* and *Plessy v. Ferguson*, African Americans continued to be underrepresented in college enrollment and college graduates. Gilbert and Heller (2013) explained that the commission believed that the only thing that should hinder a student's education or limit their enrollment was the "ability and interest of the student" (Gilbert & Heller, 2013, p. 420).

Historic Cases Grounded in Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

Historic cases such as *Plessy v. Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education*, as reviewed, have helped African Americans make strides toward inclusiveness. However, African Americans

continue to be underrepresented. Some scholars also argue that these cases, especially *Plessy v. Ferguson*, opened the door for segregation policies to exist systemically in the first place (Powell et al., 2021). Ware (2021) further explained that *Plessy v. Ferguson* provided a pathway for segregation among African Americans in the court system. Furthermore, this systematic structure began as early as the 1940s and 1950s (Ware, 2021). Ware (2021) expressed that federal government policies and rulings have not only damaged our school's systematic structure, but although segregation has progressed since the civil rights laws, the pace has been slow. This highlights the need for systemic change and the creation of inclusive campus environments to ensure the equitable treatment of African American students.

Furthermore, historic cases such as *Plessy v. Ferguson* (1892) and *Brown v. Board of Education* (1954) have also helped African Americans progress toward equity. However, African Americans remain underrepresented (Allen et al., 2018). *Plessy v. Ferguson* created "equal but separate" laws that even today impact African Americans. Reece (2021) communicated that *Plessy v. Ferguson* provided a legal foundation and discriminatory structure that continues today to block the advancement and lives of African Americans. Some scholars also argue that, although there were good intentions behind Plessy v. *Ferguson* and *Brown v. Board of Education*, Cases such as *Plessy v. Ferguson* later provided a pathway for segregation among African Americans within the court system (Ware, 2021). However, *Brown v. Board of Education* created groundbreaking developments that transformed the country into the movement of desegregation in schools, public housing, and, ultimately, higher education.

Acts and Laws Shaping Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

In addition, diversity laws such as the Civil Rights Act also protect the equity of African Americans. The Civil Rights Act of 1964 is a federal law that prohibits discrimination based on

color, religion, sex, and national origin. This Act facilitated a shift towards racial and gender diversity, paving the way for greater equality in education and the workforce (Aiken et al., 2013). This Act was a step in outlawing systematic discrimination and banned discrimination in higher education (Aiken et al., 2013). This Act holds all institutions accountable for the nondiscrimination against African American students still today.

In addition, the Equal Pay Act also holds institutions accountable for equity as it relates to the inclusiveness practices of African American students. The Equal Pay Act of 1963 prohibited employers from discriminating against employees based on sex (Vanderburg, 2020). This Act highlighted that a person's sex would not be a determining factor for higher pay. In addition, this Act caused many to examine race regarding fair wages for the underrepresented population, such as African Americans. This Act also protects African Americans in this regard. Although this is not supposed to happen today, many African Americans are paid potentially less than their white counterparts, especially in higher education.

Current Cases Defining Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

On June 29, 2023, the U.S. Supreme Court ruled to overturn affirmative action; a crucial set of policies and procedures designed to eliminate discrimination and promote equity, especially for historically disadvantage groups, in *Students for Fair Admission, Inc. v. President and Fellows of Harvard College* (Students for Fair Admissions, Inc. v. President & Fellows of Harv. College, 2023). The Students for Fair Admission argued that the affirmative action that was concluded in *Grutter v. Bollinger* was wrongly decided. Race should not be based upon admission to colleges and universities; instead, race-based preferences were unnecessary (Students for Fair Admissions, Inc. v. President & Fellows of Harv. College, 2023).

Another case that coincides with *Grutter v. Bollinger is Gratz v. Bollinger* (2023). In this case, a Michigan undergraduate student at the University of Michigan held a case regarding the affirmative action policy of a point system. The findings showed that more points were given to African Americans and other underrepresented groups (Gratz v. Bollinger, 2003). The Supreme Court ruled that the university point system was unconstitutional. This ruling hinders the acceptance of the diverse population to the university student body (Gratz v. Bollinger, 2023).

Institutions must repair the damages and act expeditiously regarding inclusive programming within our public institutions for African American students. The Supreme Court supported Grutter v. Bollinger (2003), which concluded that race could be tailored and used in the admissions decision process and that a diverse body has educational benefits. The court ruled that the Equal Protection Clause did not prohibit narrowing the use of race in admissions (Grutter v. Bollinger, 2003*). Grutter v. Bollinger* opened the door to affirmative action and enabled African Americans to have an open door regarding diversity within an institution. How do we ensure that African Americans at our institution have inclusive programs in the future?

Disparities and Gaps

Although progress has been made in promoting diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming, there remains a pressing need for further advancement and systemic change (Sotto-Santiago, 2020). Persistent gaps, disparities, and challenges continue to affect both students and institutional leaders. Sotto-Santiago (2020) conducted empirical research to examine African Americans' perspectives on diversity within an academic setting, using purposeful sampling in a medical academic environment. African American and Latinx faculty participated in 60–90-minute interviews addressing topics such as equity, diversity, inclusion, and justice. The findings revealed recurring themes, including a lack of institutional mission and

vision, the prevalence of a “win-or-lose” system, and the perception among African Americans that they must work twice as hard to prove themselves daily. Additionally, faculty participants expressed an urgent need for greater inclusiveness and reported that authentic diversity was largely absent.

Retention rates for African American students continue to fall behind those of their White peers (Greenstein, 2019). Wai and Worrell (2020) noted that many talented students from low-income backgrounds encounter disadvantages in the education system as early as kindergarten and elementary school, limiting their potential to both access and succeed in higher education. Addressing these disparities requires a clear understanding of the contributing factors, which include limited access to quality education, systemic discrimination, and insufficient support and resources for students from underrepresented communities.

Wai and Worrell (2020) examined the role of standardized testing in perpetuating educational disparities. They argued that such assessments often fail to adequately measure the potential of students from disadvantaged backgrounds or those lacking the financial resources available to many of their peers. This limitation creates significant barriers to educational attainment and reinforces existing inequalities. Addressing these inequities requires educational leaders to acknowledge the gaps and actively work toward closing them, despite the systemic challenges involved. This raises critical questions: How can equity be achieved through inclusive practices for African American students who have been denied opportunities since early childhood? Furthermore, what strategies can dismantle these inequitable systems and replace them with structures that promote fairness and access for all?

DEI Programming and Mental Health of African Americans

A lack of inclusive environments at predominantly White institutions (PWIs) affects not only the academic growth and retention of African American students but also their mental health (Leath et al., 2023). According to Leath et al. (2023), campus racial climate—the collective perception of the racial environment—shapes how African American students view and experience their institutions. While many campuses have implemented diversity-related initiatives and programs, the effectiveness of these efforts varies widely, and African Americans continue to report negative perceptions of their PWI environments. Leath et al. (2023) noted that African American students often encounter unwelcoming or even hostile institutional climates, which can exacerbate mental health challenges. In higher education, such environments compound already high stress levels and diminish the sense of belonging necessary for students to succeed and thrive (Wright-Mair, 2020). Strayhorn (2019) emphasized that a sense of belonging is a fundamental human need, essential for personal well-being and persistence in academic settings.

Timmerman and Volpe (2023) emphasized that campus climate plays a critical role in supporting mental health in higher education. When students encounter an environment that does not reflect a sense of belonging or seem to value them as members of the community, their psychosocial well-being and mental health may be threatened. Such conditions can contribute to a state of hypervigilance—a heightened state of emotional alertness and sensitivity to potential threats—which is known to worsen mental health. Hypervigilance, characterized by constant watchfulness, can be both exhausting and detrimental to overall well-being (Timmerman & Volpe, 2023).

Clause and McKnight (2018) noted that fostering more inclusive campus environments can help universities achieve greater success in diversity efforts. Clark and Mitchell (2018) added that African Americans in higher education often face stressors related to whether to conform to, or resist, cultural stereotypes. The fear of reinforcing negative stereotypes can itself create significant stress, adversely affecting both social and academic functioning, and ultimately hindering mental health.

Student Experiences with DEI Programs and Practices

African American students are increasingly voicing their experiences regarding inclusive practices and programs on campus. In a study conducted by Lewis and Shah (2021), African Americans attending a predominantly White institution (PWI) shared their perceptions and experiences with diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming at their university. The research took place at a large public university in the southern United States with a student population that was 10% African American and 77% White. The purpose of the study was to evaluate the university's DEI initiatives and analyze African American students' experiences, including the impact on their mental health. Many participants described their experiences as unsatisfactory. Themes that emerged from the interviews included surface-level diversity without genuine inclusion, diversity and inclusion framed through a whiteness-centered lens, and a sense of conditional or absent belonging (Lewis & Shah, 2021).

Participants also reported that DEI programs appeared designed primarily to fulfill institutional quotas rather than to create meaningful change. Several students described feelings of isolation and alienation on campus. One senior geography major stated, "I feel like I am disposable and that I'm just a temporary and momentary thing" (Lewis & Shah, 2021, p. 198). Similarly, a biology major shared, "I feel alone a lot of the time" (Lewis & Shah, 2021, p. 198).

Addressing these concerns, Lewis and Shah (2021) emphasized the urgent need to restructure DEI programming at PWIs. Despite existing initiatives, the culture, environment, and overall structure of these institutions remain unwelcoming. The authors called for action from both researchers and administrators to move beyond symbolic DEI events toward critical examination and restructuring of these efforts. They further recommended applying Critical Race Theory (CRT) as a framework to dismantle racialized perspectives and systemic policies and practices.

The importance of relationship building, campus climate, and mentorship was underscored in another study with African American transfer students at a Midwest PWI. These elements were found to be vital to the success of African American students (McCall & Castles, 2020). In this study, the participants included six African American students and seven staff members aged 18-24. The findings emphasized that a supportive campus climate and culture significantly impact the experiences of African Americans at PWIs. Moreover, the study highlighted that mentoring, effective communication, and well-designed programming are key to the success of African American students at this Midwest PWI (McCall & Castles, 2020).

Equity Planning in Higher Education

Many universities acknowledge the impact that inclusive practices and programs have on underrepresented populations such as African Americans. In response, they are committing to developing initiatives to improve their capacity in this arena. The Partnership for College Completion, an organization that supports colleges and universities in equity planning, was established in 2016 (Partnership for College Completion, 2022). It is a guiding force of support to colleges and universities as it relates to strategic equity planning. The Partnership for College Completion is a non-profit organization that works with colleges and universities to develop and implement strategies for improving campus equity and diversity (Partnership for College

Completion, 2022*).* We will examine the equity plans implemented by leaders of three PWIs in the Midwest: Midwest university one, Midwest university two and Midwest university three. We will focus on the African American student population.

Equity Planning at Predominantly White Institutions

Midwest university one, a PWI, has developed an equity team to ensure inclusive practices are implemented. This university has developed the following initiatives to ensure inclusive practices are in place. The following are to be implemented: 1. Eliminate all non-college-level math courses and revise repeat policies 2. Provide supplemental instruction in all gateway courses with high D/F/W and/or equity gaps 3. Develop contextualized math pathways for meta majors and increase access to adaptive 4. Learning math labs 5. Invest in an inclusive teaching and learning model that promotes curricular redesign, culturally responsive teaching strategies, and innovative professional development 6. Remove bias processes that hinder access to financial aid and influence admissions decisions 7. Leverage financial aid to support affordability 8. Build capacity in mentoring programs for students of color Partnership for College (Partnership for College Completion, 2022).

In addition to Midwest university one, another Midwest university has also developed initiatives. Midwest university two plans to incorporate inclusive initiatives: 1. The EAB (Education Advisory Board) will track and support African American students, and the EAB will support students with Pell Grant eligibility. 2. Increase the number of full-time academic advisors 3. Use the Multicultural Student Support services to support African students and hire DEI professionals to highlight gaps and help eliminate disparities. 4. Increase grant funding for populations who need it and use the Gateways to Completion program (Partnership for College Completion, 2022).

Furthermore, Midwest university three has also implemented initiatives. The Partnership for College Completion (2020) highlights that this university has the following initiatives to be implemented: 1. Incorporate Trio programs that acknowledge and address equity gaps among African American students. 2. Implement professional developments that address faculty and overall staff efforts to address equity gaps amongst African American students 3. Design an aim high program that rewards student merit and accomplishments for varied income levels of students and African American students 4. Develop an "Equity Advancing Collaborative" that consists of academic program initiatives to address existing equity gaps from annual equity scorecards.

These universities have a common initiative theme: increasing funding and developing programs to close inequitable gaps. As it relates to DEI programming, all these universities have equity mission statements. The mission of University One is to improve student outcomes by identifying and removing barriers that disproportionately hinder currently underserved populations' academic achievement and student experience. Midwest university two mission include keywords such as being built on diversity and committing to growth to become more diverse. In addition, the third Midwest university mission highlights its commitment to ensuring diversity for all students, regardless of racial or economic background.

Midwest university three also has an equity statement that reflects its commitment to student support, student achievement, professional and personal goals, diversity and inclusion, and accepting varied perspectives from stakeholders such as students, faculty, and the overall community. This university is guided by its core values, and the statement emphasizes commitment to student success and achievement (Partnership for College Completion, 2022).

While significant progress has been made in inclusive practices at these Midwest universities, the journey is far from over. Administrators and leaders are actively implementing initiatives, but it is important to remember that instituting inclusive practices is an ongoing learning process. The question of how to properly implement inclusive programs to support the growth, development, mental health, and sense of belonging for African Americans remains. Examining leadership in higher education and its impact on this influence is essential.

Leadership Commitment to Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion

Leaders are key to how DEI efforts impact institutions of higher education (Alves, 2022). Leaders must create an authentic and inclusive environment to reach marginalized groups. Many institutions acknowledge the importance of DEI policies and practices to the institution's mission and programming; sometimes, this may be inauthentic as it stands with PWIs, as sometimes these institutions appear to strive to just meet a certain quota (Barnett et al., 2020).

After conducting a study of 653 students at a PWI in the Midwest, Barnett et al. (2020) concluded that leaders and administrators should design a curriculum that includes social justice and appeals to all students. They should also ensure that teaching practices are free from microaggressions and that campuses foster authentic peer interactions. Barnett et al. (2020) argue that this is the key to successful inclusive practices at PWIs. Barnett et al. (2020) also stress that universities should not just state their mission statements but fully implement them to ensure DEI is genuinely in place on their campuses.

Other findings suggest that leaders and administrators should implement missions and social justice outcomes while listening to the needs and wants of the student body, faculty, staff, and other stakeholders (Barnett et al., 2020). Barnett et al. (2020) urge leaders to refrain from decreasing their pivotal role in DEI; emphasizing that DEI is everyone's business. However,

Barnett et al. (2020) urge DEI leaders to make it a priority for other leaders who are in sync with the vision. They insist that they must not just talk about the actions, but put their words into action (Barnett et al., 2020).

Furthermore, Evatt-Young and Bryson (2021) explained that leaders in higher education also have a critical role, especially white leaders who significantly influence promoting and creating inclusive organizational structures for a more diverse population. Evatt-Young and Bryson (2021) highlighted that leaders must dig underneath systems of normalcy and structures. Ensuring DEI implementation includes tracking data (National Civic Review, 2021). University leaders must share data with all stakeholders to ensure change. Universities have an essential role in sharing data on what is currently working, what needs improvement, and what gaps still, in fact, exist. According to the National Civic Review, narratives grounded in data allow policy changes and data interpretation to bring about real change.

Regarding leaders in higher education challenges, Tevis and Pifer (2021) expressed that having skilled leaders in a university who understand bias can help institutions with inclusive practices. Tevis and Pifer (2021) explained that higher education practices have historically been hostile towards DEI programs. Tevis and Pifer (2021) suggested that this should be examined and considered in order to implement diversity.

Dali (2018) explained that stakeholders expect specific ethical standards and behaviors from diversity leaders. However, Dali (2018) raises the concern of whether or not diversity and inclusion leaders actually "practice what they preach" (Dali, 2018, p. 2). Dali (2018) explained that as diversity leaders, we have the human right to make diversity efforts " just, fair and human" (p. 2). Dali explained that leaders and administrators can do this because they have the ability and have been appointed to do so, and that they are the voices of the people. Dali (2018)

further explained the significance of self-narratives and the need for more experience in addressing the challenges many leaders face in their DEI efforts.

Self-narrative is defined as being culturally rounded and publicly fair while not taking chances or risks, doing enough to discuss the issue but not implementing the action (Dali, 2018). In addition, Dali (2018) also mentioned that leaders should exhibit this and need more experience, explaining that many leaders must discuss inclusion in their daily practices. Dali (2018) calls for leaders of diversity who are role models for change and those who are always searching for and developing ways for improvement as it relates to diversity.

Implementation and Practices to Improve Climates

How do leaders properly get to where they need to be regarding inclusive practices at their universities? In planning for inclusiveness, Wright Mair (2020) explained that environments must be inclusive and welcoming. Wright-Mair (2020) also suggested that educational environments at PWIs should have mentoring relationships with marginalized populations within departments, colleges, and the university. There should be recognition among faculty of mentorship work and promotion that also occurs for faculty (Wright-Mair, 2020).

In addition, Wright-Mair (2020) recommended equity centers. Equity centers should be a safe space to connect with people with identical backgrounds and similar identities (Wright-Mair, 2020). Creating these spaces will bring diversity, equity, inclusion, and a sense of belonging (Wright-Mair, 2020). Vacarro et al. (2020) described a sense of belonging as an essential human need. Thus, this sense of belonging will help marginalized groups, especially African American students.

Clause and McKnight (2018) further explained that establishing a more inclusive environment positions universities to succeed. Williams et al. (2018) also explained that having a

diverse student body creates a competent workforce. Clause and McKnight (2018) further suggested that institutions' safe spaces provide opportunities for spontaneous collaboration with others. Also, Clause and McKnight (2020) suggested that leaders incorporate and host diversity programs frequently and that are intentional.

In addition, Mercer et al. (2021) suggested some implementations of inclusive practices: Implementing a curriculum that exhibits representation of marginalized groups, advertising and communicating diversity efforts in emails, open question sessions, and showcasing institutional initiatives. Mercer et al. (2021) finally suggested that having ambassadors, student support programs at universities, and role models that support diversity and increase human resources and personalized relationships would be beneficial.

Mercer et al. (2021) suggested that mentorship and student support programs are crucial to helping marginalized populations, such as African Americans. Wright-Mair (2020) explained that student support programs develop a sense of belonging and connection, especially for African Americans.

The student support program in this study started during the Civil Rights movement. The student support program is funded by the Midwest university, and to this day, this program helps countless African Americans and underrepresented students succeed in college.

Among public PWIs in the Midwest is another university that has a support program for students. This university also has a program to assist and develop African Americans and underrepresented students. The program was founded in 2004 to help recruit the underrepresented population. The primary goal of this program is to recruit, retain, and graduate more students of color. The program offers outreach in scholarships, financial aid, career development, and outreach programs. The program also offers academic advising and support,

tutoring, and a writing coach program. Today, this support program has helped the university earn 1,208 degrees. Eighty-seven percent of students have obtained a bachelor's degree, and three percent have a master's degree.

In addition, another well-known Midwest PWI has a program that fosters a sense of belonging and inclusiveness. This program supports African Americans and underrepresented students. This program was developed in 2008 and focuses on admissions and the financial aid process before students get to the university. This student support program brings high school juniors and seniors together on campus every fall. Admissions developed this program, and one of the primary goals is to bring a diverse population to campus. Once students are on campus, there is much support for outreach. One of the programs is a mentorship group that launched in 2021, which aims to assist African American males and provide mentorship and support for African American men as they transition through the university

With student support programs, implementing inclusive practices and fostering a sense of belonging among African American and underrepresented students, it is imperative to consider how student support programs foster a sense of belonging, especially for African Americans and marginalized groups. Foxx (2021) explained that despite progress, African Americans still need higher retention and graduation rates at PWIs.

Foxx (2021) contributes this to microaggression, invisibility, hypervisibility, and exclusion from campus experiences with staff and peers. To help increase a sense of belonging, Foxx (2021) suggested that African Americans be presented with more positive relationships, programs, and safe spaces that foster a sense of belonging. These safe spaces should build community, uplift, and support, as well as strengthen and foster acceptance (Foxx, 2021). In fact, after conducting a study on the sense of belonging for African Americans at PWIs, Foxx (2021)

concluded that joining programs, activities, and building relationships develops belonging for African Americans on campus. A sense of belonging not only assists in developing belongingness but also helps accelerate academics (Strayhorn, 2019). Racially minoritized students need a sense of belonging because many PWIs feel isolated and unwelcoming (Wright-Mair, 2020). Universities are advised to have more underrepresented students, diverse staff, and institutional programs (Foxx, 2021). Researchers are also being called to develop and implement safe spaces for African Americans to increase their sense of belonging and decrease these negative experiences. This study addresses a gap in scholarly work as it highlights the historic components of DEI programming, the hindrances and systematic policies and practices that influence DEI programming and most essentially tell the narratives of African American students and their relationship to a student support program and how DEI programming is beneficial.

Summary

The purpose of this research is to examine diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) programming for African American students and its relationship to student support programs. This study also seeks to understand how universities incorporate inclusive practices, particularly for African American students, and to analyze the institutional role in advancing these efforts. In addition, it explores how inclusive programs at predominantly White institutions (PWIs) foster a sense of belonging among African American students and how this sense of belonging contributes to their academic and personal success.

This literature review investigates DEI in relation to inclusive programming and practices, their implementation, and their impact on belonging. The analysis draws on scholarly literature, peer-reviewed journals, and the historical development of DEI programming within universities. It examines systemic structures, persistent gaps and disparities, and the influence of

higher education leaders in promoting diversity among African American students. It also evaluates institutional supports and initiatives for DEI programming. Furthermore, the review considers the implementation of inclusive practices at several PWIs, assessing institutional initiatives, current and future goals, and stated missions of equity. The analysis evaluates how these institutions represent inclusiveness and foster a sense of belonging. While progress has been made in advancing inclusion for African American students, substantial work remains.

This study specifically examines the growth, development, and sense of belonging of African American students at PWIs, as well as the ways in which student support programs contribute to their success. The experiences of African American students at PWIs are not uniform; some may not have experienced a lack of belonging or participated in mentorship programs. Similarly, challenges related to belonging and mentorship are not exclusive to African American students and may also affect other racial groups. This study seeks to identify common themes and provide in-depth insight into future implications that can support African American student success at PWIs. Future research focusing on oppression and identity may further illuminate and address the experiences of African American students (Hunter et al., 2019).

CHAPTER III

METHODOLOGY

This qualitative research examines how student support programs can influence African American students' success at PWIs. This study is guided by a central and compelling question: How does DEI programming impact inclusiveness and support a sense of belonging among African American college students?

This research will also examine how inclusive programming supports the growth and development of African American college students.

As an African American woman from Illinois who attended the Midwest PWI student support program, the researcher has firsthand knowledge of the sense of belonging, personal growth, and empowerment fostered through the student support programs. Attending the student support program gave the researcher the sense of belonging and support needed to complete two degrees at this university. As a first-year student in the student support program, the researcher also had an advantage over her peers. The researcher met monthly with a success counselor to assess the needs needed to succeed in classes, and coming in as a freshman, the researcher experienced ample help.

Many student support programs with mentors and counselors have advised many students on their path to education. The researcher had much help in their student support program, completing financial aid and counseling on navigating her classes properly. Coming in as a freshman in the student support program, the researcher took a few extra classes designed to help her succeed in the program and at the Midwest PWI in general. Being in the student support program helped the researcher feel a sense of belonging because she had support and people around who cared firsthand about her success as a student.

The researcher experienced struggles with a math class her first year as a freshman. The student support program directed her to a tutoring center that helped her navigate and later successfully complete the math class needed to proceed to sophomore year. In addition, the researcher's grade point average was relatively high at a 3.0 and higher throughout her college experience. The researcher credits her academic achievement to the student support program, which was always willing and ready to assist and help ensure the researcher-maintained success. This motivation, support, persistence, and connectedness is just what the researcher needed to thrive; to belong.

Programs like the student support program the researcher belonged to help students feel like they belong. The researcher felt this sense of belonging in the student support program throughout her five years at the PWI and even in obtaining a higher education degree. If the researcher was not involved in the student program and received the extra support, the first year of college and so forth may have been even more challenging.

Today, this support program's primary mission is to provide underprivileged students with academic, financial, social, and organizational support. This student support program does this through one-on-one support, personal introduction to resources, an orientation experience, and peer mentoring and support. The support program also offers comprehensive one-on-one support, assigning each student a success counselor and an academic advisor. Students are also introduced to a range of campus resources, including the Bursar's office for financial aid, Housing and Residential services, and tutoring. The program also provides an orientation experience, where students attend a leadership conference and receive advice on school, careers, and time management from experienced speakers.

The student support program goal is to provide mentorship and support to students. Mentors assist students in adjusting to their academic lifestyle and social environment on campus. In the program Assessment Summary Report, 300 students were asked about their experiences. When asked about their confidence in fitting in socially, 128 students said they were very confident, 68 were quite confident, 49 were somewhat confident, 19 were a little confident, and six were not confident. When asked about the benefits of peer mentorship, 97 students strongly agreed, 56 moderately agreed, 94 students marked does not apply, 13 moderately agreed, and 16 strongly agreed.

Significantly, this study holds potential because it focuses on a student support program at a Midwest PWI in Illinois. This study will explore the support of this program as it relates to diversity and belonging. With the researcher having her own impactful experiences with the student support program, the researcher will delve into the stories and perspectives of other African American students whom have graduated within the same student support program within the last three years and share their lived experiences, stories and thereby highlight the crucial role of student support programs in shaping the academic journey of African Americans at a PWI.

The student support program in this study started during the Civil Rights movement in the 1960s, shortly after the assassination of Martin Luther King Jr. During this time, two alumni wanted to help disadvantaged African Americans catch up and overcome barriers leading up to commencement. Their persistence and desire to see African Americans succeed at a PWI sparked the development of the student support program, allowing African Americans and other minorities, even today, to successfully enroll at the university while maintaining close support through advising and support during the first few years of their college journey.

In the student support program, students receive mentorship and support from an advisor and full support throughout their college experience. The program, which initially started with a small number of students, has grown to accept 1,500 – 2,000 students in any given year, creating a large and supportive community.

Therefore, this research will focus on students who have attended the student support program at the public PWI in Illinois. This research will examine how this single program and others have fostered student support and a sense of belonging in their African American students college experiences. To obtain knowledge, this research will explore how a single Midwest PWI in Illinois incorporate inclusiveness within their institutions while acknowledging gaps, and inconsistencies regarding African Americans and highlighting African Americans' growth and develop and how this program foster their sense of belonging overall.

Qualitative research will be used in this research. The purpose of qualitative research is to truly understand how people make sense of their lives and their experiences and to interpret and unfold these experiences (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Insight into their experiences and common themes will be gained through interviews to gain insight into their perspectives and experiences concerning DEI programming and a sense of belonging. In learning about the real-life experiences of African American students in student support programs at this Midwest PWI, the intent is that the findings in this research motivate leaders and policymakers to urgently address any disparities in DEI and highlight how a sense of belonging may have a positive impact on African Americans experience at PWIs. This research is also intended to stimulate advocacy for African American students to become agents of change for inclusive programming at universities in Illinois, potentially leading to significant policy changes and increased support for these students, thereby fostering a more inclusive, equitable, and belonging higher education system.

As a former student of a student support program, the researcher may have some potential bias that raises concerns about this research. As an African American woman with a background in education and a graduate of a PWI student support program, the researcher is also aware that her perspectives shape her experiences and viewpoints. In addition, the researcher has experienced the impact of DEI programming and belongingness with her experience in the student support program and understands the potential impact of such programs on the experiences of African American students at PWIs. However, the researcher has approached this research from a factual standpoint, drawing on the voices of participants' experiences in this study. The researcher is committed to transparency, intending to examine this study from both factual and narrative standpoints, presenting and relying solely on facts and processes that do not influence personal opinions or beliefs. The researcher is also drawing on the CRT and sense of belonging theory to guide the analysis of this research, which informs her understanding of DEI programming and a sense of belonging. Additionally, all data will be collected from interviewees and data-based systems.

African American students continue to experience systematic racism, a lack of implementation of equity-based policies, and disparities in enrollment, retention rates, and resource allocation (Allen et al., 2018). It is not just essential but urgent to address these disparities in DEI among African American students, who are often left marginalized and underrepresented, and explore what might be necessary in aiding in the success of African Americans at PWIs. Wright-Mair explained that student support and mentorship programs are key to the overall success of African Americans at PWIs (Wright-Mair, 2020).

Research Methodology

Qualitative research collects qualitative data, such as words or pictures, and non-numerical data (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). Qualitative research is also an exploratory or "bottom-up" approach, where the researcher constructs information, hypotheses, theories, and data during fieldwork (Johnsen & Christensen, 2020, p. 33). The purpose of qualitative research is to truly understand how people make sense of their lives and their experiences and to interpret and unfold these experiences (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). In conducting qualitative research, one accomplishes the following: How people interpret their world and experiences, how they construct their worlds, and the meanings they attribute to their overall experiences (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016, p. 24).

The personal nature of this study aims to explore inclusive programming through a student support for African American college students as it relates to their growth, development, mental health, and sense of belonging at public PWIs, will allow for a deep exploration of the experiences of interview participants and the development of themes and meanings. This approach ensures that the participants' experiences and perspectives are at the forefront, adding depth and authenticity to this research. It's a testament to the commitment to understanding and addressing the challenges faced by African American students.

Research Method

The research method is the overall design and strategy used in research (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). Research methodology is a strategy that guides a research plan and exhibits a theory of how one should proceed, whereas research methods include methodological considerations (Jones et al., 2022). There are several research methodological approaches to conducting a study.

Narrative inquiry allows participants to share their experiences and allows the researcher to understand their experiences (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). This narrative process will be conducted through interview questions. In this narrative inquiry, eight to ten African American students will share their perspectives to gain insight into the experiences of this population. Narrative inquiry is the applicable and useful research method for this study. Narrative inquiry is more sufficient for this study than other qualitative methods because it allows one to describe their lived story descriptively without certain restrictions and limits and it allows one and others to delve deeply to understand events in a meaningful whole (Jones et al., 2022). Narrative inquiry also gives a voice to marginalized populations that may not be otherwise heard.

Narrative inquiry is also better for this research, as it gives first-person accounts of experiences and their meanings to center stage (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Narrative inquiry is a methodological research approach that relies heavily on one's life experiences narrated by those who have lived them and gives stories and descriptions of a series of events (Jones et al., 2022). Narrative theorist also defines narrative inquiry as a "distinct form of discourse" that is meaningful through experience, understanding other actions, and sequencing events and objects while making connections over time (Jones et al., 2022, p. 99).

Using narratives of the participants' life experiences that relate to DEI programming and experiences of the Midwest PWI student support program that foster students' sense of belonging will help obtain essential information for key components of this study. The information in this study will rely on participants' experiences and themes found in correlation with the narrative method after conducting interviews.

Research Population

The population for this study is African American students in higher education at one PWI university in the Midwest in Illinois. African Americans have had many experiences related to education and DEI programming as a whole. It is pivotal to examine these experiences and challenges and to hear real-life narratives of this population's experiences and how student support programs and other belonging programs can positively contribute to African Americans' success. The population for examination is African American students who have attended a student support program at a Midwest PWI in Illinois.

Sampling Criteria

Sampling criteria refer to "variables, characteristics, qualities, experiences, and demographics" that are linked directly to the purpose of the study (Jones et al., 2022, p. 139). In this sampling criteria, African American alums of the student support program will be examined closely regarding DEI. Diversity among this population is limited in several spaces, which has guided sampling decisions (Allen et al., 2018).

All African American participants have attended the one Midwest PWI student support program in Illinois. All participants have a bachelor’s degree from the university and have graduated from the program and institution. In addition, the sample size was nine former African American student support program students. Having nine African American students from a homogeneous population was valuable to this research and allowed me to closely examine, analyze, and retell the participants' experiences.

The more homogenous a population is, the smaller the sample size should be and the more heterogeneous a population is, the larger the sample size should be (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). Nine African American participants ensured a strong sample size, as

according to Bekele and Ago (2022) six to eight interviews are enough for a homogeneous sample and six to twelve interviews are enough to uncover and understand major issues in any study. Also, nine participants allowed an ability to conduct in depth interviews and allowed saturation. Saturation occurs when the researcher starts to hear the same themes or reoccurring ideas (Jones et al., 2022).

Furthermore, limitations of this sample size are that there are over 1500 members who have graduated from this single student support program and nine participants accounted for a small percentage of all students. Also, information from interviews were be based upon participants' personal experiences and perspectives. Other limitations may include participants' own biases that influenced responses in their storytelling of their experiences. However, to minimize limitations, there were specifications in identification of criteria.

Clearly identifying criteria is essential to sampling (Jones et al., 2022). In this regard, in identifying eligible participants to participate in the study, an honor system in the form of a screener survey asked all participants if they acquired a bachelor's degree. In addition, participants do not have to live in Illinois currently but must prove that they have attended the support program. Furthermore, all participants were asked if they identify as African Americans on the screener survey. An online screening tool was used to capture the criteria and demographic information of the participants, and privacy and confidential protections was provided in the documentation. All participant information was stored on a secure platform.

Sampling Strategy

The sampling technique consisted of purposive sampling. Purposive sampling specifies the characteristics of a population of interest and then locates this population (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). The identified population was nine African American former student support

program students. Their experiences relating to this DEI programming and support in this space was assessed. In using purposive sampling, giving not only the criteria but also the why of the criteria is essential (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016, p. 97). This study was chosen as African American students have been marginalized, and there is a need for development, growth, and an examination of the effects of a sense of belonging and if student support programs foster African American student's sense of belonging (Allen et al., 2018).

Sampling and Recruitment

Gaining access to participants is sometimes challenging, but having relationships makes this process easier (Jones et al., 2022). Snowball sampling is a common form of purposive sampling that involves locating a few participants who meet the criteria and then asking for more participants who meet the criteria. The snowball gets bigger and bigger (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Therefore, snowball sampling was implemented for this study through assistance from the student support program to identify African American alumni participants. African American alumni participants were recruited through Gmail with an email notification from the director of the Midwest PWI in Illinois student support program. Upon the researcher request, the program director of the Midwest PWI sent an email out to students for recruitment. In contacting participants, participants were asked of other potential participants' recommendations for contingency plans for recruitment.

In addition, participants were contacted at least three times to follow up and ask for their interest in participating. After locating the population, internet interviews were conducted. Zoom platform will be utilized to conduct Internet interviews. Codes and themes within the interview process for data purposes were also noted. Interviews consisted of an interview guide approach. Johnson and Christensen (2020) expressed that an interview guide approach has open-ended

questions and is not in any order. Interview questions were open-ended and did not have to be answered in any specific order when collecting this data.

Data Collection Instruments and Procedures

The methodological approach of examination was conducted through a narrative inquiry with interviews. Semi-structured interviews were used for this study. Semi-structured interviews are flexible, broad, and have open pre-established questions (Jones et al., 2022). Semi-structured interviews have no particular order, and they are the most common type of interviews used in research where they allow consistency and flexibility in informally asking questions about one's feelings, a particular order of events, or the significance of a topic that gives participants freedom in responding (Jones et al., 2022). Semi-structured interviews in this study lasted 45-60 minutes each through Zoom.

Face-to-face interviews are commonly used and are the most standard method of interviewing. However, there are more feasible and cost-effective methods today (Gray et al., 2020). In this regard, semi-structured interviews were conducted through Zoom, a private video and audio-conferencing service. Zoom allows participants to be geologically dispersed in various places within the world while cohesively communicating on a video conferencing platform (Gray et al., 2020)

Furthermore, in utilizing Zoom, there was one round of 45–60-minute interviews with nine participants selected from African Americans through purposive sampling. Through narrative inquiry of interviews, storytelling, and open-ended questions were asked to gather data and retain themes. In addition, a general interview guide design approach was used for semi-structured interviews. The interview guide approach, in sync with semi-structured interviews, is

an interview that ensures that the same amount of information is used with each participant while also allowing freedom and leverage in the interview process (Turner, 2010).

Participants were able explain their experiences in detail in any order as long as each open-ended question was touched upon at some point during the interview. While conducting the interviews, the focus was on the plots and structures of participants' stories (Jones et al., 2022). In addition, boundaries of where participants' stories begin and end, as well as listening and knowing when some stories bring to the surface strong emotions was carefully examined (Jones et al., 2022).

In conducting interviews, questions were centered around questions that lead to increased insight. Questions had the following categories such as the following: introduction questions, follow-up questions, probing questions, direct and indirect questions, structuring, interpretive, background, behaviors or experience, opinions and/or values, knowledge, feelings, and sensory (Jones et al., 2022, p. 182).

Segmenting is the process of dividing data into meaningful analytical units (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). In addition, coding uses segments of descriptive data with symbols, descriptive words, and category names (Johnson & Christensen, 2020) was used. In reviewing interviews, segmenting and thematic coding was implemented to search for themes while using coding to explain types of support, numerical themes, and so forth of the experiences of African American students within these public institutions.

The purpose of this study is to explore inclusive programming among African American college students and their relationship to a student support program and examine their development, growth, and mental health within these public universities. This research is essential as there is a passion for DEI programming efforts among the African American student

population and a need for African Americans to not only survive but thrive in PIs. There is no denying the hardships of African Americans who had to persevere more to obtain support for educational attainment at PWIs. This story is just one of many to be told narratively for data purposes and change. Therefore, narrative inquiry into participants' stories and life experiences as they relate to DEI programming and a sense of belonging will help guide data collection for this study. Information will be collected through interviews, segmenting, and thematic coding.

Data Analysis

In preparation for data analysis, interviews were first transcribed. All interview data was also stored on a Google document Excel spreadsheet, with questions listed and each participant's response. This information was stored on a secure platform. Only the researcher had access to this data.

In transcribing data, you do not get the intimate familiarity of your data when hiring someone to transcribe, as you would in transcribing the data yourself (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Therefore, all data was transcribed through vivo coding. In transcribing semi-structured interviews of 45-60 minutes for each participant, all nine interviews were recorded on Zoom, and observations was taken while documenting notes during and after the interviews. In addition, open-ended question responses were reflected upon by watching the complete recordings of all interviews while taking additional notes to ensure sufficient data.

In organizing documents for content review, the data was arranged from interviews by segmenting and coding to develop recurring themes. Furthermore, summarization of interview notes was conducted by finalizing themes and developing graphs, tables, and charts to interpret data to make the data more visible and easily readable research findings.

Data analysis is the process of making sense of your data (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). The process of data interpretation is "ongoing, emergent, unpredictable, and unfinished" (Jones et al., 2022, p. 213). In this research, narrative inquiry was analyzed. Forms of narrative inquiry include developing a categorical analysis where units are derived from "completed stories" (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016, p.33). Units of themes was collected from interview transcripts in this data inquiry. However, there are no exact or best practices for the analysis of stories that are collected (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). After collecting all interview notes in the first round, transcripts were carefully read in search of many codes, highlighting words, reactions, and occurrences to develop the themes collected. The first coding round develops many codes that must be reduced to more significant concepts later in analysis (Jones et al., 2022).

The second round or level of review of interview transcripts will use open and thematic coding of my interviews (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Vivo coding provides insight into emotions within a story and focuses on participants' concerns and displays of action (Jones et al., 2022). Open coding allowed me to jot down notes and analyzed any data that was relevant to the study (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Thematic coding secured and coded data in the research and developed themes, while also allowing a close examination and efficiency of data (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016).

In addition, the restorying process was implemented in this narrative inquiry for the third round after organizing data. The restorying process closely relate to the environment, time, and relationships, gathering the participant's responses and stories from the interviews and then co-constructing and retelling participants' stories within a chronological sequence while acknowledging key essential elements and themes.

Ethical Considerations and Reliability

Furthermore, ethical considerations, validity, and reliability was ensured in this research. As a former student of the student support program, the researcher may have some potential bias that raises concerns about this research. The researcher's interpretation of data may have been influenced by their own experiences as well as perspectives, however efforts were made to eliminate this to ensure these beliefs did not alter data or analysis. In managing the researcher bias given the researcher's personal connection to the student support program, the researcher examined this study from a factual and narrative standpoint solely on the perspectives and experiences of the nine graduates of the student support program. Data was only interpreted from interviews and historical and current research findings. All data was collected from interviewees and data-based systems to ensure validity and reliability.

Ensuring that validity and reliability are present in qualitative research involves conducting one's research ethically (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). When research practices are conducted to be trusted, they must be ethical (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). Additionally, to ensure trustworthiness and research validity, the following two methods were used: Member check/ respondent validation.

Member checks, also known as respondent validation, is the process of taking back information from the people you have conducted a study of (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). In a final debriefing, all data was returned to interviewers, and interviewees were asked if the findings were "plausible" (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016, p. 246). Data consisted of themes from all participants collectively and from Partnership for College data findings after segmenting and vivo coding. Finally, tables, charts, and data graphs were developed for visual and understanding purposes. In addition, feedback on findings were asked from the participants interviewed. This

eliminated any misconceptions or biases. All participants were asked whether the research and findings were accurate to ensure their stories have been properly retold and analyzed.

Research participants were required to give their informed consent before research began. All participants were informed of the nature of the study and given information about why the study is taking place in a recruitment email. Participants signed a consent form. The consent form provided the purpose of the study and the length. In addition, participants were informed of the confidentiality of the study and provided names the participants may contact for questions regarding the study (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). Concluding the consent form indicated that the study was voluntary and that participants may withdraw at any time (Johnson & Christensen, 2020).

The purpose of this study is to explore DEI programming for African American students in PWIs and to examine their growth, development, mental health, and experiences as it relates to inclusiveness and a sense of belonging. Conducting this study and the findings will benefit higher education and develop a deeper understanding of DEI programming, and a sense of belonging among professionals in the field and students overall. This study will serve as a guiding force of what is absolutely necessary to ensure the success of African Americans at PWIs.

CHAPTER IV

FINDINGS

This narrative study aimed to examine the experiences and perceptions of African American students while attending a student support program at a Midwest public university in Illinois. The research question that guided this study is the following: How does DEI programming impact inclusiveness and support a sense of belonging among African American college students?

This research was examined and highlighted through narrative interviews of nine recent graduates within the last three years of a student support program at a Midwest PWI in Illinois. The goal of this research was to unravel the detailed experiences of these graduates and understand their experiences related to their educational experience and DEI programming as a whole. This study examined the experiences and challenges of this population, unraveling real-life narratives from their perspectives, and explored how a single student support program can positively contribute to African Americans' navigation to success within a predominantly White institution (PWI).

This chapter examines the demographics of participants, provides a summary of each participant, and presents the findings derived from semi-structured interviews and data analysis. All interviews were conducted and recorded on the Zoom platform. Zoom is a private video and audio-conferencing service that allows for communicating on a video-conferencing platform (Gray et al., 2020). Transcripts were coded using vivo coding, open coding, and thematic coding. Open and thematic coding were used to organize and analyze the interview transcript data, with coding and emerging themes identified. To develop trustworthiness in the interview process, participants were asked clarification questions during the interview, and the researcher conducted

member checks. Member checks involve taking information back to the source or participants to verify accuracy (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016).

Participants

Participants were recruited through the director of the student support program of the Midwest PWI. All participants were sent a recruitment email from the director. When the graduates of the student support program responded to the recruitment email, they were then sent an introductory email and consent form to be signed. The eligibility criteria of participants were the following: a) Identify as an African American alumni of the Midwest PWI b) obtained a bachelor's degree within the last three years of the Midwest PWI and student support program c) had experience in the student support program d) have had some experience with DEI in their public PWI and student support program.

The data collection consisted of nine students interviewed over the course of two weeks. There were two African American females and seven African American males who were interviewed. Each participant was asked a total of ten questions. Participants' responses were recorded with their verbal permission, and the interviews were transcribed. Each participant brought their unique experiences, perspectives, and interpretations and detailing narratives. Table 1 shows the nine participants of the Midwest PWI who were apart of this study. The participants overview includes all nine students' gender, age, major and their graduation year from the institution and the student support program. Psydonyms were also assigned.

Table 1: Participant Overview

Participant	Gender	Age	Major	Graduation
Grace	Female	29	Health and Human Sciences/ Family and Child Studies	2022
Carl	Male	24	Engineering Technology	2025
Jonathan	Male	26	Electrical Engineering Technology	2023
Joy	Female	25	Communications	2022
Jack	Male	23	Industrial Management and Technology Engineering	2024
Paul	Male	24	Engineering Technology	2025
Mario	Male	26	Theater Studies and Communications	2021
Luke	Male	*23*	Health and Human Sciences	2024
George	Male	*36*	Sports Management Education	2023

Grace

Grace was the first participant to be interviewed. Grace is a 29-year-old African American female. Grace graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2022. Grace graduated with a Bachelor of Health and Human Sciences with a minor in Family and Child Studies. Grace explained how she wished she had joined more organizations on campus. She emphasized the importance of organizations, meeting more people, and forming a stronger connection. Grace stated that her sister also attended the institution, and she spent a lot of time with her sister, wishing she had met more people while at the Midwest PWI. Grace also wanted me to be aware that she came from a rather diverse background. She attended a diverse grammar school and high school.

When asked about DEI and a sense of belonging, Grace explained that DEI and a sense of belonging to her was "coming together to understand." Just as Mercer et al. (2021) suggested

that mentorship and student support programs are crucial in helping marginalized populations, Grace highlighted how the student support program at the Midwest PWI she attended, included everyone, which helped her feel like she belonged. She stated, "It really helped me. I loved how they did not discriminate. Just because someone doesn't get a certain score on their ACT, it does not mean that they are inadequate enough to go to college." Grace was referring to how the student support program, with a lower ACT requirement, gave students the opportunity for admission. Grace also later shared that she came from a very diverse background, from her early school years through high school and college, so she understood diversity rather well.

Carl

Carl is a 24-year-old African American male. Carl graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2025. Carl graduated with a Bachelor of Science in Psychology. Carl was very candid about his perspectives and experiences. When asked about DEI and a sense of belonging, Carl stated that he thinks of people really coming together when he hears those words. Carl stated it means "Being decent human beings, not being separate. If you're not accepting someone based on differences, that's not being genuine." Wright-Mair (2020) also explained that feeling a sense of belonging is a basic human need.

Carl went on to highlight that the student support program at the Midwest PWI brings everyone together. Carl stated, "The program makes you feel like you are never alone. It is not just for African Americans; it is for everyone." Carl explained that he felt a sense of belonging being a part of the student support program, but not necessarily in his classes. Carl stated, “I felt a sense of belonging within my community. I always felt like I had a family. The times I did not feel a sense of belonging, honestly, would be in the classroom.”

Carl expressed that the Midwest PWI did not have much support and that his biggest support was the student support program counselor he received. He said, "It was not until I spoke with my counselor that I got the classes and help that I needed." Carl later adds that he wished he had also a mentor at the Midwest PWI, stating that there was little to no mentorship. Wright-Mair (2020) explained the significance of mentorship to develop a sense of belonging and connection, especially for African Americans.

Johnathan

Jonathan is a 26-year-old African American male. Jonathan graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2023 with a major in Electrical Engineering Technology. Jonathan was very confident in his interview and displayed a great interest in DEI and belonging. Jonathan opened up about how, back in high school, he was not able to focus and that his student support program counselor was great and he could talk to her about anything. In referencing the student support program, Jonathan stated that the program "was my whole experience with DEI, and it gave me a sense of belonging.

When asked about DEI and sense of belonging, Jonathan explained that DEI and a sense of belonging was bringing everyone together and not "judging a book by its cover." As Grace explained, Jonathan also emphasized the need for DEI programs that focus on diversity and belonging. Jonathan expressed how there was a mentorship program, "Black Male Initiative," and the significance of how this program influenced other African American males.

Jonathan also explained how he had to really reach out for support, as he stated, "People were not going out of their way to include me." According to Sotto-Santiago (2020), African Americans often find themselves having to work twice as hard to prove themselves. Jonathan later explained that one teacher told him his personality did not fit in the electrical engineering

program. Jonathan explained that this teacher was not supportive of him; however, other students supported him on his behalf as they disagreed with the teacher's words.

In addition, Carl and Jonathan reiterated that their student support program advisor was their greatest influence. Jonathan also stated this, explaining that his student support program advisor went above and beyond, helping him with classes, offering advice, and instructing him on how to develop his schedule to increase his GPA. Jonathan explained the benefits of knowing this and how it guided his educational journey and experience.

Joy

Joy is a 25-year-old African American female. Joy graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2022 and was a Communications major. Joy was very concise and straight to the point in her interview. The researcher wanted to talk more with Joy; however, her personality seemed quiet and reserved. The researcher was, however, glad that she went through most of the interview questions, even if they were concise.

Joy expressed that when she thinks of DEI and belonging, she considers equity as a key component. Joy stated, "Just make sure everyone is included." Joy later explained that she felt like she belonged and that she had a sense of community at her Midwest PWI. Joy, just as Grace, Karl, and Jonathan explained, highlighted the significance of joining organizations. Joy informed me that she had joined several African American organizations on campus. Joy stated that while in the student support program, she received a surplus amount of assistance, including educational advice, guidance counseling, and financial and career advice.

Joy also expressed that she never felt race was a factor in the success of her educational attainment and that she did not have a DEI experience on campus. Joy said she pretty much belonged and that she had a community. In referencing the Midwest student support program,

Joy stated, "They did a pretty good job making sure everyone felt seen and heard. If we had a question about anything, they pretty much helped."

Jack

Jack is a 23-year-old African American male. Jack graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2024. Jack graduated with a bachelor's in industrial management and technology engineering. Jack appeared laid back and quite intelligent. Jack valued relationships and friendships with peers. This was easily noted and reflected through the several organizations on campus that Jack stated he was a part of in his interview. Jack was also transparent about his earlier academic success, stating that the student support program he was involved in at the Midwest PWI provided him with the opportunity to attend college, despite not having the best grades. Jack later explained, "They opened the door for me to attend…" referring to the student support program allowing him to attend the Midwest PWI despite his past academic record.

When mentioning DEI and belonging, Jack stated that DEI and belonging to him is equal opportunity. Jack stated that he was involved in several organizations that fostered this feeling of belonging. They were the following: The National Society of Black Engineers (NSBE), NAACP at student support program, and a Christian organization on campus. Jack expressed that he felt a sense of DEI and belonging through the friendships and organizations in which he was involved. When asked about DEI and belonging as it relates to policymakers, Jack explained that "everyone should feel a sense of belonging, especially at a university." Clause and McKnight (2018) suggested that establishing a more inclusive environment positions universities to succeed in DEI.

Paul

Paul is a 24-year-old African American male. Paul graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2023 with a major in Engineering Technology. Paul is a first-generation college student. Paul was very outspoken during the interview and was eager to answer interview questions. Paul explained that he was a leader while on campus and was a part of several organizations. Paul also stated that he was a part of a fraternity. It was rather easy to notice that Paul was a leader, as evidenced by his confident conduct during the interview and his ability to ask leading questions.

When Paul was asked about DEI and a sense of belonging, he stated that he thinks of everyone as a whole, “Not being separated as far as programs. Everyone being treated equally.” Paul later highlighted that being in leadership helped him feel a sense of belonging. Paul stated, “I always had a sense of belonging and was a part of leadership. I know a lot of people who felt like they didn’t belong because they were not in a leadership position.”

Later, in the interview, Paul also mentioned how the Midwest PWI was building a center that his fraternity and others were helping to develop, allowing students to connect more effectively. Just as Wright-Mair (2020) suggested, providing campus equity centers creates a safe space for connecting with people who share similar backgrounds and identities, and developing these spaces brings DEI and a sense of belonging to light (Wright-Mair, 2020).

In addition, as Dali (2018) explained that leaders impact change for DEI, Paul urged policymakers and leaders related to DEI and belonging to invest in all aspects of DEI and belonging. Paul stated, "Invest in us as much as they invest in them. We have to do so much on our own." Here, Paul is referencing the struggles African Americans face. Allen et al. (2018)

elaborate on these struggles, communicating that often African Americans have to work twice as hard in higher education.

Mario

Mario is a 26-year-old African American male. Mario graduated from the Midwest PWI student support program in 2021 with a Bachelor of Arts in Theater Studies and a Master of Arts in Communications. Mario was very open during his interview. When asked what comes to mind when thinking of DEI and a sense of belonging, Mario responded, "Everyone getting a say." From the start of the interview, it was clear that Mario was confident in his academic and social abilities. Mario stated that he was a part of an organization on campus, the Black Male Initiative (BMI), just like several other participants. He explained that this program also helped him be successful at his Midwest PWI and gave him a sense of belonging. As Strayhorn communicated, a sense of belonging not only fosters a sense of belonging but also helps accelerate academic achievement (Strayhorn, 2019).

When referring to his student support program, Mario stated that his entire experience with the program centered on DEI, reiterating that it had helped him, as he did not initially have the necessary scores to attend the Midwest PWI without the program's assistance. Mario stated, "My entire career was based off DEI."

Mario mentioned that the student support program taught him how to study and navigate his classes, and he stated that his student support program advisor was influential in his success. Mario, commenting on the care of advisors in the student support program, mentioned that from the first day you start as a student, there is a group of people who care about you all the way until the end of your time in the program. Mario stated, "The first day you meet someone in the program, they are thinking about your graduation. Mario also mentioned in regard to the student

support program that in just attending a school, you can have so many advisors. However, this was not the case with the student support program. Mario stated, "Advisors can change every semester at a school, but the program counselors stay with you."

Luke

Luke is a 23-year-old African American male. Luke graduated in 2024 with his bachelor's degree in health sciences. Luke shared in his interview that he was a part of a fraternity at his Midwest PWI. He also connected DEI with his fraternity. Luke stated that his fraternity gives back, sharing that they give $800 to two students for books, rent, and other student needs. Luke also emphasized that leadership plays a crucial role in DEI and that his fraternity, along with others, has the capacity to make a positive impact in others' lives.

When asked what comes to mind when thinking of DEI and belonging, Luke mentioned, "I think of some type of program. I think of someone to look over people that need to be taken care of." Luke spoke highly of his student support program and credited the program with providing him a scholarship that funded his educational journey. Luke also mentioned that he gained his support from his student support program, and the program helped cultivate his experience of DEI and belonging at his institution. According to Mercer et al. (2021), mentorship and student support programs are crucial to helping marginalized populations.

George

George is a 36-year-old African American male. The interesting key about George is that he is a two-time graduate of the Midwest PWI. George graduated recently with his Master's in Sports Management in education in 2023. He also graduated in 2017 as an undergraduate with a bachelor's in communications and an emphasis in Journalism. George also had vulnerability and shared with me that he was removed from the Midwest PWI in undergrad; he explained that he

was so focused on taking care of everyone else that he neglected his own studies. George stated that it was his mentors from the student support program who helped him, two years later, get back into the institution. George stated, "During my undergrad, I was overly involved. I was voted president of the NAACP, elected to be treasurer of an organization, and vice president of another. George goes on later and expresses, "I felt obligated and kept pushing it back and back. Here, George was referring to his schoolwork.

George was very honest about his experiences at his Midwest PWI and student support program. When asking George about DEI and belonging, he explained, "A sense of belonging is being accepted and having a safe place for everyone. It is more of a level of inclusive excellence among all levels and demographics." George later added. "I also think of those who do not have the best in life and or who may not feel they are represented fairly."

George also shared that he now works at the Midwest PWI, and because of his struggles and challenges, he can easily connect with students. George stated that the students he interacts with are often surprised when they find out he was once removed from school due to his academic difficulties. He shared that students having knowledge of this helps him connect with his students and lets them know that he once faced challenges and that these challenges can be overcome with hard work and dedication.

George also credits his program advisors for being influential in his educational journey, and referring to them as the reason he was successful. George expressed that being part of organizations helped him feel like he belonged and were his biggest support in completing his undergraduate and graduate studies. This aligns with Foxx (2021), who expressed that participating in programs, activities, and building relationships fosters a sense of belonging

among African Americans. A sense of belonging not only fosters a sense of belonging but also helps accelerate academic achievement (Strayhorn, 2019).

The questions in Table 2 were asked to unfold the story of each participant with their experiences of DEI and belonging and their student support program at their PWI. There were 10 questions asked in total of each participant. Table 2 represents the focal point of each question asked. Following, student responses are captured and highlighted. Themes are developed through coding; participants' responses are recorded. Student interviews use quotes to detail student experiences and to give an overall real-life perspective of each participant and also their experiences.

Table 2: Interview Question Focus

Number	Interview Question Focus
1.	Belonging
2.	Experiences on Campus
3.	College Experiences and Sense of Belonging
4.	Student Support Program Experiences
5.	Policymakers Support
6.	Sense of Belonging at Institution.
7.	Student Support Program Supports and Educational Experience
8.	Changes to College Experience
9.	Race in Educational Attainment
10.	Policymakers and Leaders

Belonging

All nine participants were asked the same set of 10 questions. Question one asked: when you think of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) and a sense of belonging, what comes to mind? All nine of the participants responded that they think of being included and that it involves everyone and togetherness. Other keywords participants used were equity and equality in response to this question. Jonathan stated, "Being among all different races of people and being able to be included coming from my background; not judging a book by its cover." Joy mentioned she thinks of equity and later stated, "Everyone is included." Mario shared, "Everyone getting a say." George further explained, "A sense of belonging is being accepted and having a safe place for everyone." Grace stated, "All of us coming together." In addition, another participant added, Paul, "Everyone as a whole. Everyone being treated equally. Finally, Jack concluded, he thinks of "equal opportunity."

Experiences on Campus

In question two, participants were asked about a time when they experienced DEI on campus. Three of the participants associated an organization, Black Male Initiative (BMI) with DEI. Both explained that this organization made them feel proud of their culture. Grace stated, "It was a program where Black men would walk around campus in tuxedos, like businessmen." Grace further explained, "To see Black men walk around in suits and dress shoes; it made us look so nice." Paul also mentioned BMI in his response to question two; however, he had a different perception of his experience. Paul stated that he was an actual member of BMI. Paul expressed that he remembered how BMI was once accused of not welcoming others, and he stated that this was false. The other participants referenced organizations and campus events that made others feel included in relation to DEI. Mario also explained he was a member of BMI and

stated that the organization helped him. Mario shared, “I was also a member of BMI to help Black males.” George shared that being a member of NAACP and the student support program helped him experience DEI. Joy was the only participant who stated she did not have an experience with DEI on campus.

College Experiences and Sense of Belonging

Question three asked participants to describe their college experience in relation to DEI and belonging. Some participants referenced their student support program as their DEI and experience of belonging in itself. Carl shared that with the student support program, you get grouped with people that bring you together. He also shared that the student support program set the course for his college experience. Luke stated regarding his student support programs and experience, “Being able to be in an organization with other people to share goals and aspirations made a space to be able to create new ideas and build on existing ones.” Other participants explained that the root cause of their feeling of DEI and belonging was also being involved in organizations. Grace even mentioned that she wished she had joined more organizations for the inclusiveness. George credited his college experience and sense of belonging to organizations and stated, “I was always involved.” George stated that one of the organizations he was a part of was BMI was influential and also credited his student support program counselor to his success.

Student Support Program Experiences

Similar to question three, question four inquired about the participants' experiences with DEI and belonging within their student support program. All nine participants stated that the student support program helped them feel like they belonged, helped them succeed, and opened doors to opportunities for them. Mario stated that the school should implement a student support program for all students, even those who do not necessarily require it for academic purposes.

Mario shared, "It pushed me over the edge taking classes coming in. Peers who were not in the program were having issues." Jack expressed that the student support program gave students and himself the open door to help them know what they wanted to do in life. Jack stated the student support program give students, “an open door and help them know what they want to do in life.” Grace stated, “I love the student support program, and they made me feel comfortable.” Later, Grace stated the program also made her feel “included.” Luke also explained, “The student support program was a great example of DEI on campus.” Joy goes further and explained that the student support program, “makes sure everyone is seen and heard.” Finally, when explaining the program Jonathan added that the program and his counselor helped fostered his belonging as well. Luke expressed that the student support program and his advisor, “put that battery in my back and really added to my sense of belonging.”

Policymakers Supports

Question five discussed the policymakers' influence and asked participants if there was room for development and growth. All nine participants agreed that the university could do more in this aspect and some stated that they have seen improvements. Jack stated that it would help if the Midwest PWI would reach out to students more. Joy stated that the university was doing a good job but just needed to make sure everyone was included. Paul stated that he later started to see a difference. Paul shared, "I think at first, when I got to campus, I did not see good images of DEI. Now I see they have rebuilt these images." Carl stated that policymakers are neutral, stating they try some but do not do enough. Jonathan explained, “I think they are trying to say that DEI is discriminatory. It is not discriminatory; it is to help students.” Paul stated, “When I first got to campus, I did not see good images. Now I see they have rebuilt those images.” Paul also asserted his fraternity being a part of these changes to help DEI. Finally, Mario stated that now with the

institution new woman president that this in itself is creating “a good environment for everyone to be apart.” George stated that he also feels there has been improvement commenting, “Everyone in general is supported and it is more so of what you need.”

Sense of Belonging at Institution

When participants were asked question six— how they experienced a sense of belonging at their institution while attending, and, conversely, how they did not— their responses reflected patterns that were largely anticipated. Several participants indicated that they experienced belonging primarily through involvement in student and participation in student support programs. This theme emerged consistently and was reinforced across multiple interviews.

Similarly, a common theme was found when several of the students described not feeling like they belonged in their classes. Some expressed feelings of not belonging due to the uprising with the COVID-19 pandemic, which hindered them from interacting with their peers in their early years at their institution. Alternatively, Jack shared that he especially felt a sense of belonging while being involved in his engineering organization. Jack shared, “I was involved in a lot of clubs on campus and was able to develop friendships and relationships.” In relation to the COVID-19 pandemic, he stated, "I would say at the very beginning, COVID happened in 2020, and everything was virtual, and everyone kind of knew each other. I felt I had to catch up. Meeting new people took time."

In referring to organizations, Joy shared, "I felt I had a sense of belonging due to the organizations I joined." George shared that his advisor in his student support program fostered his belonging. In referring to his student support program and advisor George shared, “It was like I trust her and them; I have worked with them.” Luke stated that he started feeling a sense of

belonging once he started joining organizations. Luke explained, “I started to feel a sense of belonging once I started joining clubs and organizations that were aligned with my beliefs.

Student Support Program Supports and Educational Experience

Participants were asked in question seven what supports they received in the program and how did this guide their educational experience. All nine participants mentioned their student support program counselor and how influential they were in attributing to their success. In reference to her advisor, Grace shared, "She was like a therapist in a type of way. You could talk to her about anything. She really helped me." Other participants highlighted their counselors and the student support program and how their counselors provided advice regarding their GPA, classes, and studying schedule. The participants referred to their counselors more as mentors and explained that the counselors were also influential in their everyday lives. Luke shared, “ I received scholarships, mentorship, a solid network and this guided my educational experience because it allowed me to be in a situation where I had to do everything alone.” Jack expressed, “My advisor reached out to me to see if I needed anything and that if my grades were good.” Jonathan stated that his advisor was a support to him, He shared, “She was my biggest support and helped guide my educational experience.” Finally, Mario explained, referring to his advisor, “She taught me how to study, how to get my classes. She gave me the gems when I went to her.”

Changes to College Experience

Question eight asked participants what they would have wanted in their overall college experience and what year of college was the most difficult or easiest. Carl expressed that besides his student support program, he would have enjoyed a mentor. Carl shared, "I wish I had a mentor. It was little to no mentorship. It is nothing that is set in place to succeed. You literally have to put yourself out there." In addition, as it relates to the easiest or most difficult year, all

nine participants stated that the easiest year was their freshman year. Many of the participants stated the program help them early on academically. Participants also stated that there was a surplus of support entering as a freshman in the student support program as well. Mario shared, "I would say that the student support program made my freshman year the easiest." Jonathan shared, 'Freshman year was my easiest. No effort freshman year ." George shared, My sophomore year was the hardest year. Freshman year was easy." Jack stated, "My easiest year would be my freshman year." Similarly, Luke stated, "The easiest was definitely my first year and the most difficult was my last year. Finally, Grace shared, "The easiest year was freshman year and the most difficult was junior year."

Race in Educational Attainment

Question nine allowed participants to be candid about their experiences, as it asked them to describe a time when they felt that race was a factor in their educational attainment. In reference to this question, one of the participants, Jack, explained a situation with campus police and how he felt misunderstood. Joy, Grace, and Karl, on the other hand, stated that they never had an experience. Paul shared an experience that occurred in an online class with a professor, where he was the only African American in the class, and the teacher stopped and stated that he was not capable of using educated language. Other participants explained rather positive experiences or none. Paul shared that his teacher in an online class stopped the class while he was talking and stated that he was unable to use "educated words." Paul shared that he never heard much from the teacher after this incident. Paul emphasized that campus authority was strict, stating, "You know, at some of the events, someone would get arrested." Here, Paul references the differences in African Americans having events on campus from other cultural

groups and stated that many times, events hosted by African Americans would get shut down by the authorities.

Policymakers and Leaders

To conclude the interview questions, the last question asked was “If you could tell policy makers and leaders of your institution one thing about DEI and belonging, what would that be and why?” All nine participants expressed that they would tell policymakers to include everyone and invest in everyone equally. Paul stated, “Everyone should feel a sense of belonging, especially at a university. Mario suggested that the institution incorporate the student support program as a whole at the university. Mario shared, "The student support program is the reason every school should be doing it." Grace urged policymakers to create and develop more inclusive events. Jonathan urged policymakers to also attend events to see what they are about. Joy emphasized that everyone should have a 'fair' opportunity. Joy also highlighted that events such as Juneteenth should be celebrated and urged policymakers to make all feel included. George stated that he would urge policymakers, “that it is necessary, it is needed, and it is a tool of empowerment.” Carl shared, "To be honest, people say treat others how you want to be treated. I always say to treat people like you treat your family members. Treat a random stranger the same as a close family member and watch the change you will make.” Finally, Luke expressed. “The earlier you start implementation, the stronger the results will be.”

Theme Identification

Transcripts were recorded in a Word document. Interviews were coded and transcribed in three rounds. The first round included in vivo coding, which was used in reviewing transcripts from interviews. In the second round of interview transcripts, open coding and thematic coding were used to analyze and group the data and identify themes of my interviews. The third round

consisted of verifying accuracy and rereading transcripts from interviews to confirm accuracy, and subsequently populating codes, themes, and categories.

Theme 1: Student Support Program Fostered Inclusiveness and Sense of Belonging

Participants were asked about their student support program. All nine participants stated that the student support program fostered inclusiveness and a Sense of Belonging. Jonathan shared:

> The student support program gave me a chance. I was an average student in high school. My counselor, she was great and helped with anything I needed. I would come to her office, and we could just talk about anything. The student support program was my whole experience with DEI, and it gave me a sense of belonging.

Other participants shared their perspectives in relation to the support program. Carl shared:

> The student support program makes you feel like you are never alone. It is not just for African Americans; it is for everyone. They always make you feel like you belong. It is a family away from home. The student support program brings everyone together.

All nine of the participants emphasized how the program fostered inclusiveness and belonging, and also how their advisors played a key role in their educational attainment. Carl shared:

> My counselor was the biggest part. I realized my original college counselor was not helping me as much. I will never forget I was told to take a bunch of economics classes. It was not until I spoke to my student support program counselor that I got the help I needed. The program bettered my educational experience and made it convenient.

In addition, Grace also shared the following:

> I love the student support program, and they made me feel comfortable. It did not matter what year I was a student, they always made me feel included.

During the interviews, participants expressed their gratitude for the student support program. and emphasized how the student support program changed their life. George also commented:

> My experience was phenomenal. It is also not like the resources stop coming to you. It is set up for you to succeed. The program sets you up to succeed.

Theme 2: Organizations Created a "Belongingness" and Sense of "Inclusiveness"

All nine participants linked belongingness and inclusiveness with the involvement of organizations. Those who were not part of an organization also expressed a need and a desire to be part of one. Participants expressed the benefits of the organizations. Jack shared:

> I felt a sense of belonging, especially with my major in engineering, so I was able to connect and develop friendships with others that I have encountered. I was involved in a lot of clubs on campus. For example, The National Society of Engineers (NSBE), the NAACP, and a Christian club.

Paul contributed being involved in organizations helped him feel included. Paul also emphasized that having leadership roles in organizations also fosters inclusiveness and belonging. Paul stated:

> I always had a sense of belonging and was a part of leadership that had to. I know a lot of people who felt they didn't belong because they were not in a leadership position. They were really not involved.

Several of the participants stated that the organizations gave them what they needed. Joy shared:

> I felt a sense of belonging due to the Black organizations that I joined.

In addition to feeling of belongingness and inclusiveness, Mario also mentioned that being a part of Black Male Initiative (BMI) and Collegiate Men organizations helped him feel like he belonged. Jonathan also shared that BMI was influential to him as well. Grace highlighted the

importance of organizations in DEI and belonging. Grace shared:

> I feel like I wish I would of joined more organizations that related to DEI. I admired it when I saw it, but I never joined an organization. I would have like to join more organizations. My sister and I are a year apart, and our coming together kind of stopped me from being involved in organizations.

In discussing organizations and participants, it was obvious that most of their feelings of belongingness and inclusion came from their student support program and organizations that they were involved in.

Theme 3: Lack of Sense of Belonging with Community Authority

In relation to the participants' college experience, five of the nine participants highlighted that they had experiences with law enforcement. Mario shared:

> There was a problem with the police. It was summer break, and school had just let out. Someone called and said we had guns. They all had their guns out. We had water guns. No way you can see a Super Soaker and say they had guns. That probably was the only time I felt out of place, and the way they talked to us.

Participants shared their experiences of defining moments of lack in belonging. Paul shared:

> One thing I can think of is that whenever there is an off-campus event, the police are strict. Some organizations have predominantly Caucasians and some predominantly African American. At some of the events, someone would get arrested. Someone got arrested at a predominantly Black event.

George also explained that he had a similar experience where he felt a lack of belonging and Inclusiveness. George highlighted that this incident was a memorable time to him:

> Another time, I was walking home after a party. I got stopped, and another police car was there, too. He takes my ID and goes to the car. I asked the other officer what I was being stopped for, and the other officer said that he did not know. The officer came back and asked if I knew the reason I was stopped. The officer told me it was because of my hat and pulled a picture of another person with the same hat. The man in the picture was about six feet, heavy-set, and light skinned. He asked what my fraternity was and where was my fraternity house. I told him I did not have one and was headed home. Luckily, someone was in the parking lot that knew me. I would say that is one of the most moments for me, distinctively. Everything could have gone spiral.

Jack also explained where he felt a lack of belonging with campus authority. Jack shared:

> One thing I can think of is that whenever there is an off-campus event, the authority is really strict.

Summary

The participants provided insightful, candid, and transparent accounts of their experiences in their student support program while enrolled in the Midwest PWI. In coding the semi-structured interviews, three essential themes were disclosed. The three themes revealed were the following: (a) student support programs fostered inclusiveness and a sense of belonging, (b) organizations created a sense of belonging and inclusiveness, and (c) Lack of a sense of belonging with Community Authority.

The first theme, student support program fostered inclusiveness and a sense of belonging; participants recounted their experiences in the student support program. Participants reflected on the impact the program had on their overall educational journey. Participants highlighted that the

program significantly shaped their educational journey, providing them with the necessary support and tools to navigate and successfully graduate from the PWI.

The second theme, organizations created a sense of Inclusiveness" and "Belongingness," participants were forthcoming about how joining their organizations gave them feelings of belonging. All participants mentioned DEI and organizations, highlighting the significance of how their organizations have helped them feel a sense of belonging or have helped others. Those participants who were not involved in organizations also emphasized the importance of organizations, their desire to be part of one, and the potential difference that joining an organization could have made in their educational journey.

The final theme, lack of sense of belonging to community authority, was expressed by participants who shared their frustrations with law enforcement and associated this with their sense of not belonging. The participants allowed their selves to be vulnerable and candid in telling the account of their experiences at the Midwest PWI. Chapter 5 will further examine the Critical Race Theory, findings, recommendations, and implications for future research. These recommendations will help policymakers and administrators understand the importance of student support programs for African American students at PWIs and how they can promote DEI programming and a sense of belonging, not just through student support programs, but also in the classroom, on campus, and in the community

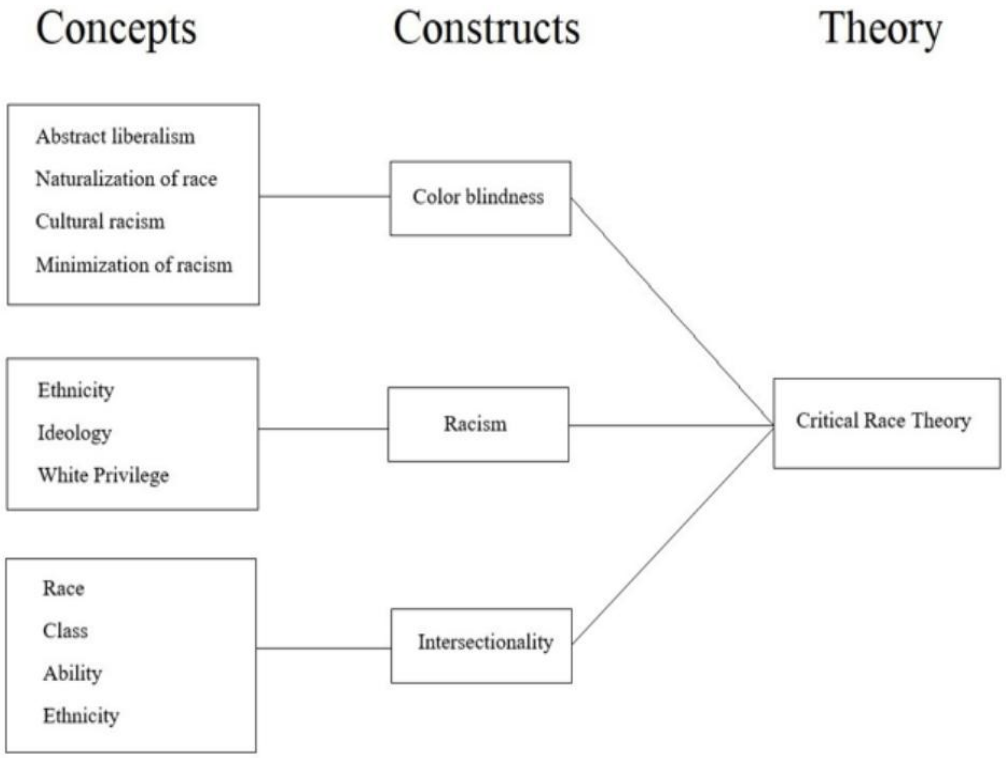
CHAPTER V

DISCUSSION

This study explored inclusive programming for African American students in higher education at a Midwest PWI. The focus was on their experiences during their time at the Midwest PWI. This chapter provides findings from The Critical Race Theory (CRT), an overview of the study, discusses findings in the study, implications for future research practices, and provides suggestions for future research.

Figure 3

CRT Concepts and Constructs



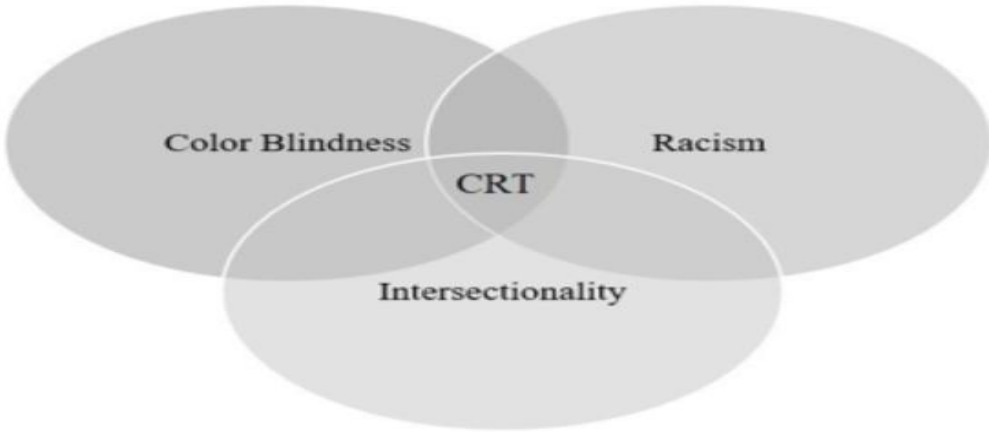
Note: This figure illustrates the CRT Model of concepts and constructs of the theory (Movius, 2020).

Shown in Figure 3, CRT and constructs are highlighted. Figure 3 demonstrates how these constructs form the CRT. This study frequently references color blindness, white privilege and race. These concepts are not only mentioned in historic components; however, they are also brought to the forefront in some of the narratives of the participants in the study. According to Movius (2020) deconstructing these current systems of color blindness, racism and intersectionality can lead to less oppression and more importantly foster advocacy and awareness.

The figure below shows the intersecting constructs withing Critical Race Theory.

Figure 4

Constructs in CRT



Note: This figure illustrates constructs in CRT (Movius, 2020).

In relation to color blindness, Figure 4 highlights that color blindness, race, and intersectionality are interconnected (Movius, 2020). According to Movius (2020), color blindness focuses on one's commonalities and humanity; however, it often lacks equity and, in return, functions as racism. Additionally, racism seen in figure 4 is described as having privilege

over another group, also known as white privilege (Movius, 2020). Movius (2020) mentioned constructs of CRT, which are ethnicity, ideology, and white privilege, and white privilege influences systematic decisions. Concluding, Movius (2020) demonstrated that one's race, class, ethnicity, and ability can create groupings or social categorizations that typically result in discrimination against the dominant group by the other, thus creating systems with multiple forms of discrimination and inequality (Movius, 2020).

Despite advancements, African Americans still experience the disadvantages of systemic racism and a lack of implementation of equity-based policies (Allen et al., 2018, p. 44). All of students who were interviewed experienced some aspect of the Critical Race Theory. This was evident in the stories they shared, whether in a class, on campus, with law enforcement, or in their personal experiences, overall, as they relate to DEI and Belonging.

Paul, a participant in the study, shared what happened in his online class with his teacher and how he was treated; whether this was knowingly or unknowingly, on the teacher's behalf, it did occur. Jonathan, another participant, later explained that one teacher told him his personality did not fit in the electrical engineering program. Additionally, several participants mentioned that they struggled to rent rooms for organizational events on campus, whereas it seemed relatively easy for students from other cultures.

The five tenets of CRT are: Racism is ordinary, interest conversion, social construction, racialization, and storytelling highlight these struggles and stances (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023). Delgado and Stefancic (2023) expressed that racism is ordinary, and we see this is evident in the incidents students experience in the classroom. In this context, color blindness and discrimination may be blatantly apparent (Delgado & Stefanic, 2023). There was blatant disrespect given to Jonathan in the classroom when he was told he did not fit into the electrical

engineering program. Similarly, the same was true for George when he was pulled over by law enforcement and clearly did not match the identification of the prospect the officers were looking for. In addition, this is the same for Paul, who experienced a similar situation in the classroom when he was told he could not use educated words.

The second tenet, interest conversion, is also emphasized in the experience of the participants. Interest conversion is the idea that racism benefits elite and working-class whites, and therefore, society has little interest in eliminating it (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023). Interest conversion is evident in how participants mentioned that they struggled to have events on campus where African Americans were represented, but it was, however, easy for students of other cultures to host events on campus. This could have been done intentionally, but it is from the stance of interest conversion. Joy urged policymakers and leaders to focus on events that celebrate African Americans and to make these events for everyone. For example, Joy stated that holidays like Juneteenth should be celebrated, and that policymakers should make it known that they are in support. Joy stated, "Make us all feel included."

There is no doubt that the student support program at the Midwest PWI played a significant role in fostering DEI and promoting a sense of belonging among participants. However, institutions also have sole responsibility. Leaders in higher education should strive to create an inclusive organizational structure for a more diverse population (Evatt-Young & Bryson, 2021).

The third tenet, social construction, posits that race is a product of social thought and relations. Racial categories in this tenant are created by society. Historically, racial groups have been categorized and classified. For instance, Jack explained how some events at the Midwest

PWI were shut down by the authorities. In addition, Mario explained that if you are not a student on campus, you may sometimes be treated with disrespect.

The fourth tenant, racialization, is how society racializes different groups at different times of need in the laboring market (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023). As participants explained their experiences in inclusion and belonging, most expressed a lack of inclusion and a sense of belonging, often derived from the classroom and the outside community. Also, participants mentioned that in some respects, they were perceived as being a potential disturbance, which is why their events may have been, at times, shut down.

The final tenet is storytelling. Storytelling urges African Americans and other minority groups to retell their experiences with racism, race, and daily life (Delgado & Stefancic, 2023). All participants, who were African Americans, retold their experiences and were encouraged to share their stories and their truth. The participants sharing their experiences was essential as it could bring awareness to their counterparts and help African Americans in the future.

Overview of the Study

Participants' perspectives and experiences were expressed through the sense of belonging and CRT. These frameworks helped highlight the importance of student support programs for African American students. They highlighted their struggles, successes, and strategies for navigating through a Midwest PWI. This study explored the compelling question: How does DEI programming impact inclusiveness and support a sense of belonging among African American college students? This research additionally examined how DEI-grounded student support programming fosters the growth, development, and mental health of African American college students.

Nine participants were interviewed through semi-structured interviews. Participants shared their experiences and perspectives of their accounts while being enrolled in the student support program at the Midwest PWI, detailing the experiences of their struggles and successes.

Discussion of Findings

There is certainly a need for student support programs among African Americans that provide mentorship, inclusiveness, and support while attending PWIs (Wright-Mair, 2020). Mentorship and student support programs are critical and essential for African American students at PWIs (Mercier et al., 2021). Diversity can create inclusive and diverse environments for African American students (Wright-Mair, 2020). Inclusive environments foster a sense of belonging, which is a human necessity (Vacarro et al., 2020).

In addition, campus climate and culture can significantly impact the experiences of African Americans at a PWI (McCall & Castles, 2020). Three essential themes were derived from exploring the stories of the nine graduates of the student support program at the Midwest PWI. The themes enhanced my understanding of the experiences and perspectives of the student support program graduates. These were: (a) student support programs fostered inclusiveness and a sense of belonging, (b) organizations created a sense of belonging and inclusiveness, and (c) lack of a sense of belonging with Community Authority.

Student Support Programs Fostered Inclusiveness and a Sense of Belonging

To gain a sense of understanding of participants' student support program experiences, they were asked about their perceptions of DEI and belonging. Most participants immediately connected DEI and belonging to their student support program. Nine of the participants reported having a positive experience with DEI and belonging, largely due to their involvement in the student support program and having access to great advisors and mentorship. Jonathan, Jack,

Mario, Paul, Carl, Luke, and George discussed feelings of belonging and inclusion, communicating that their student support program influenced this perspective.

In addition, participants also expressed that without their student support program, they would not have been as successful. Several participants referenced the student support program as a second family. For example, Carl stated that the student support program was like a family away from home, referencing how he felt a strong sense of belonging in the program. Additionally, George explained that his advisor and mentors in the program were like family to him as well, as they accompanied him to meet with his department chair and helped him re-enroll in the Midwest PWI.

Organizations Created Belongingness and Sense of Inclusiveness

In examining belongingness and DEI, the researcher sought to explore other factors that contributed to these outcomes. During the semi-structured interviews, all nine participants emphasized the importance of organizations and their associated aspects, such as a sense of belonging and Inclusiveness. Mario, Paul, and Jonathan shared their experiences being in the Black Male Initiative (BMI) and explained how the organization opened the door to them feeling more included while giving the Midwest PWI a more diverse feel. Mario explained that he felt like he belonged even more in this organization. Even Grace, who was not a member of BMI, explained the effects of diversity and how seeing these men on campus influenced her and the Midwest PWI. Some participants associated feeling alone or regretful of not joining organizations. For instance, Joy stated that she wished she had joined more organizations, but did not do so due to her sister also being on campus with her.

Furthermore, participants who held leadership positions in organizations were even more expressive about how organizations influence belongingness. For instance, Paul, Jack, Luke, and

George all noted that being in leadership roles made them feel more a part and included. In fact, Paul stated that some people on campus may have not felt they belonged due to a lack in leadership. Paul further shared that one of his jobs was to include others on campus as well.

Lack of Sense of Belonging with African American students and Community Authorities

African Americans, at times, experience unwelcoming and hostile institutional climates (Leath et al., 2023). Foxx (2021) attributes this to microaggression and hypervisibility that often occur at PWIs with African Americans. This microaggression was apparent in the classroom when two participants shared their experiences with teachers making derogatory comments towards them. Paul stated that while in class, his teacher stated that he could not use educated words, and Jonathan stated that his teacher commented in class that his personality did not fit the engineering program.

This unwelcoming and hostile climate is also seen in community authority. Five of the nine participants experienced hostile climates in their community with law enforcement, which resulted in feeling non-belongingness and isolation. For instance, Jack, Mario, Paul, and George detailed their experiences and how they felt afterward, which affected not only their DEI and belonging experiences but also their overall insight and mental perspectives. According to Leath et al. (2023), a lack of DEI environments can affect African Americans not just academically but also their mental health. This is highlighted when George recounts how he was pulled over and explains how it affected him. George explained that he was happy when he saw someone he knew and that the person he knew spoke well of him on his behalf. Later, George commented on the experience, "I would say that is one of the most important moments for me, distinctively. Mario also stated that in his incident with law enforcement, he felt out of place and felt he did not belong. Clark and Mitchell (2018) explained that African Americans are often fearful of

displaying a negative stereotype. This, in itself, creates stressors and affects them in their social and academic capacity. Several participants explained the impact of these stressors as it relates to belonging and DEI.

Implications For Practice

Participating in DEI programming, as it relates to student support programs at PWIs, can be the ladder to success for African American students. DEI programming, such as a student support program, may provide supplemental mentorship, support, and guidance. Through sharing their stories and perspectives, the participants and researcher discovered that the student support program at the Midwest PWI fostered feelings of belonging, diversity, equity, and inclusiveness.

Findings of this study help to accumulate information regarding the lived experiences of these recent African American graduates from a student support program in the Midwest. The findings suggest further implications and insights into student support programs and how they bring about positive change in African American students, not just academically but socially, and how they provide a "human" need for them to succeed at a PWI.

Student Support Program Fostered Inclusion and a Sense of Belonging

The research findings disclosed that the student support program fostered inclusiveness and a sense of belonging. This revelation should influence the development of student support programs to assist African Americans in their educational journey at PWIs. Perhaps not only student support programs help African Americans, but also other minority groups or all students who may be struggling in general in the college setting at a PWI. This study reveals that policymakers and administrators of institutions should closely examine the effectiveness of student support programs and implement these programs to increase overall completion rates and retention, based on participants' shared experiences.

By highlighting DEI programming through student support programs, African Americans may be better equipped for success rather than failure. Policymakers must institute and maintain student support programs and focus on DEI programming that accelerates the academic and social progress of African American students from the moment they walk into the institution's doors. The research participants have revealed that student support programs provide an improvement in academic performance, a greater sense of belonging, and increased retention. With the student support program, African Americans receive financial assistance, advising and counseling, as well as academic and career readiness support, which increases their chances of success and achievement.

Vaccaro et al. (2020) expressed that students of color need to feel a sense of belonging as a humanistic need, as African Americans usually report lower levels of belonging than their white peers. Previous research has shown that student support programs contribute to a sense of belonging, and my study suggested that these programs are beneficial. According to Wright-Mair (2020), student support programs are crucial to ensuring that African American students succeed. Mercier et al. (2021) suggested that student support programs are particularly critical for African American students at PWIs.

Organizations Created Belongingness and Sense of Inclusion

Participants emphasized how organizations created a sense of belonging and inclusion. The research participants highlighted how the absence of such organizations could create feelings of aloneness. Several of the participants stated that being a part of an organization combined with other student support programs helped them feel included and fostered the feeling of belonging. As PWI policymakers and administrators consider African American students and minorities, they should also consider organizations and programs that support African Americans

and how these organizations can contribute to their experiences on campus. Policymakers must provide organizations that foster DEI. Foxx (2021) emphasized the importance of joining programs and organizations, as they foster a sense of belonging among African Americans.

Lastly, because all nine participants shared how organizations are beneficial for belonging and DEI programming, policymakers should incorporate organizations on campus that promote the sustainability of African Americans at their campuses. Leaders in higher education should strive to create inclusive organizations that cater to a more diverse population (Evatt-Young & Bryson, 2021).

Lack of Sense of Belonging with Community Authority

Participants explained that they felt a lack of belonging due to the community's authority figures. This was revealed in some of the participants' experiences in not just their classrooms but also with law enforcement. Policymakers and the administration of the Midwest PWI should ensure that students feel a sense of belonging in all realms of the institution. A lack of belonging in the classroom and with law enforcement could potentially deter an African American student from progressing or becoming successful.

Previous research shows that lack of belonging has been historically developed. For instance, many suggest that *Plessy v. Ferguson* created policies systematically that hindered the progression of African Americans (Powell et al., 2021). Federal laws and policies have also damaged our school's systematic structure (Ware, 2021). Policymakers and administrators need to ensure that our teachers, curriculum, and structures, both in and out of the classroom, are designed to support African Americans in thriving. Leaders should ensure that the campus racial climate is fair for all students. Campus racial climate is the perception at PWIs that informs and shapes African American students' perceptions. According to Leath et al. (2023), African

Americans at times at PWIs may experience unwelcoming and hostile institutional climates. African American students often experience high stress levels and lack the sense of belonging needed to succeed and thrive in an educational setting (Wright-Mair, 2020).

Limitations

While this study demonstrates results for the benefits of a student support program, it is important to acknowledge limitations. This study sampled nine students of the student support program, which is only a portion of the broader population of 15,000 graduates thus far from the student support program. Additionally, data relied on participant reported data from one's own perspectives and experiences that may positively or negatively impact responses and data based upon student views. Future research should aim to gather these findings in a larger sample size and utilize more tools to eliminate any potential biases of participants.

Limitations and Future Research

The research in this study examined perceived impacts of a student support program and its benefit to African American students in navigating through a Midwest PWI. Did participation in this program shape perspectives of the institution's commitment to diversity, equity and inclusion. The study was comprised of nine recent graduates within the last three years of the student support program. In examining the student support program, the importance organizations have on inclusiveness and belonging and the impact of campus climate from authority in the community was revealed. Future research can provide a deeper understanding of the experiences and perspectives of students.

First, the study sampled nine African American recent graduates of a student support program. As previously noted, future research could sample a larger number of students. This

would provide a more comprehensive account of students lived experiences and offer a detailed explanation of how student support programs benefit African American students.

Second, future research can highlight not just African American students, but also students from underrepresented populations of various racial groups, such as Hispanic and Latinx. This would provide a broader perspective and insight into the experiences of these students at PWIs, offering a means for comparing findings. Having more perspectives could offer a deeper insight and connection to preexisting data and findings.

Third, in addition to a diverse racial group, focusing on a specific gender would make this research more beneficial in the future. Throughout my research, numerous accounts of the experiences of certain genders, particularly African American males, emerged. For instance, the researcher also noticed that more males were willing to give accounts of their experiences in the student support program PWI. Curiously, this caused concern, and an uprising of thoughts that possibly African American males may have more struggles at PWIs or hindrances.

Finally, future research can focus on African American students in student support programs across various periods. For instance, African Americans who graduated within the last three years can be explored, as can those who have come through the Midwest PWI program within the last 15-20 years, highlighting attention to DEI programming and offering a comparison for the policies and structures in place during that time period. For example, an African American graduate from the Midwest PWI during the Civil Rights movement may view inclusiveness and a sense of belonging differently than a graduate within the last three years of the student support program. The adjustment in time periods would certainly explain historical phenomena and provide participants with views and insight into their lived experiences.

Conclusion

African American graduates of the student support program at the Midwest PWI have revealed through their shared experiences and perspectives the importance of their student support program. The study highlighted the impact of the student support program, which provided mentorship, academic support, and, most essentially, inclusiveness and a sense of belonging for African American students. The study also examined student support programs, which, while emphasized for African Americans, also benefit all students. The themes of the study were: (a) student support programs fostered inclusiveness and a sense of belonging, (b) organizations created a sense of belonging and inclusiveness, and (c) lack of a sense of belonging with Community Authority. In highlighting the participants' stories and experiences, the study has emphasized African American students' need for inclusive programming of student support programs to be successful at PWIs. African Americans are often left marginalized and underrepresented; however, policymakers, administrators, and leaders can help change this narrative by exploring the narratives of participants in this study and taking action.

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APPENDIX A: Interview Questions

1. When you think of diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) and a sense of belonging what comes to your mind?

2. Tell me about a time when you experienced DEI directly on your campus?

3. How would you describe your college experience, as it relates to DEI and belonging?

4. How would you describe your student support program experience, as it relates to DEI and belonging?

5. How do you feel policy makers at your institution have created supports and a culture for DEI and belonging to take place and how is there room for development and growth?

6. While attending your institution, how did you feel a sense of belonging? How did you not?

7. What supports did you receive in the program? How did this guide your educational experience?

8. What would you have wanted in your overall college experience if any? What year of college was the most difficult or easiest.

9. Can you tell me about a time you felt race was a factor in the success of your educational attainment?

10. If you could tell the policy makers and leaders of your institution one thing about DEI and belonging, what would that be and why?

APPENDIX B: Interview Guide

1. Ask same questions from interview guide for each participant and allow for freedom in responses. See appendix A
2. Keep notes before, during and after interview.
3. Observe body language and strong emotions.
4. Explain the purpose of the interview to each participant.
5. Explain interview process in the beginning, detailing how potentially long the interview will be.
6. Ask participants if they have any questions or need assistance before the interview.
7. Have interview questions ready to read.
8. Read body language, as to if interview is going well or if a pause is needed.
9. Be sure to always listen at all times during interview.
10. Give participants contact information should they need to get in touch.

Note: Resources for interview guide approach are retained from the following resource

Turner III, D. W., III (2010). Qualitative interview design: A practical guide for novice investigators. *The Qualitative Report, 15*(3*),* 754-760. http://www.nova.edu/ssss/QR/QR15-3/qid.pdf

APPENDIX C: Recruitment Email Text

Hello,

I am a doctoral student at Governors State University and am writing you seeking that you may be eligible and have an interest in my research study. Below, you will find more of a description of my study:

My capstone will focus on understanding the experiences of African American alums who have attended a student support program at a predominantly white institution (PWI) in the Midwest. In understanding their experiences and the pathway to their success, particularly student support programs, mentorship, and sense of belonging will be explored.

I am seeking alums who have graduated at least 3-12 years from a student support program at a PWI in the Midwest. We know that African Americans have faced challenges and difficulties related to diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) in several spaces. I hope to interview eight to ten African American alumni during January and February 2025. All participation and discussion will be strictly confidential. Participants are also free to withdraw from this research study at any time.

The study will include a narrative study of participants sharing their direct experiences of student a support program at a Midwest PWI. There will be one interview lasting 45-60 minutes. This study will last one semester, as I wrap up my studies at Governors State University.

Eligibility criteria is limited to participants who:

- Identify as an African American alum of the student support program at a Midwest PWI.
- Identify as obtaining a bachelor's degree at least 3-12 years from the Midwest PWI.
- Identify as a person who has had some experiences with or seen DEI in some realm in their public PWI and student support program.

If you are interested in participating in this study and would like to learn more about this study, please contact me, Connie Love, at clove@student.govst.edu or 773-641-4964 or my chair, Dr. Deborah King, at dking9@govst.edu, 708-534-4542. If there are any questions about the conduct of this study or concerns regarding the study as a participant and or your rights, please contact the Division chair at Governors State University at mcummings@govst.edu or 708-534-4396

Thank you very much for your time and interest.
Connie Love
Doctoral Student, Higher Education, Governors State University
clove@student.govst.edu

APPENDIX D: Participant Consent Form

Dear Participant,

You are invited to participate in a study of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) at a predominantly white institution (PWI) in the Midwest conducted by Connie Love, a graduate student at Governors State University, under the supervision of Dr. Deborah King, program professor and coordinator in the Department of Education at Governors State University. This study explores the African American alumni DEI and sense of belonging experiences by examining student support programs that influence this impact on their ladder to success. In this study, you will be asked about your experiences, demographic information, and challenges at your Midwestern PWI. Your participation includes completing an interview of 45-60 minutes through Zoom. Questions in the interview may be viewed as personal information to you. If you do not want to answer any question at any time, please skip over the question, and we will proceed. If you would like to withdraw from the study at any time, you may also do so.

A benefit of this study is that you will learn about student support programs and how they influence African Americans. Any answers to questions will be anonymous and at no time will you be asked to disclose your name. Therefore, you will at all times remain anonymous. There is no compensation for this study. This study is solely voluntary. If you have any questions about this study, you may contact me by email at clove@student.govst.edu. If you have further questions beyond my research team and myself regarding your rights as a research participant, you may contact Governors State University Institutional Review Board through the Office of Sponsored Programs and Research at 708-534-4987.

SIGNATURE SELECTION– Please read over the directions carefully. You are deciding to participate in this research study. Signing this indicates that you agree to participate in this research study.

Name of Participant Giving Consent

Signature Date